

Arabic, Step by Step, Root by Root

An etymology-driven curriculum, built one word at a time

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This edition compiled incrementally — new chapters added as they
are written.

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Preface

This book teaches Arabic one word at a time, and it teaches each word by taking it apart. It is written for someone starting from zero — who may not read a single Arabic letter — so the script is taught *inside the word lessons themselves*: each word introduces exactly the letters it needs, right-to-left, so you learn to read سلام *and* learn that it means “peace” in the same few minutes. There is no alphabet drill to sit through first. (A reader who already reads Arabic simply skims the “letters in this word” notes.)

Arabic changes the etymology game entirely. The Romance and Germanic volumes trace words back to Latin or Germanic roots; Arabic doesn’t need tracing — its roots are on the *surface*. Nearly every Arabic word is built from a **three-consonant root** carrying a core meaning, poured into fixed patterns, so *peace*, *Islam*, *Muslim*, and the greeting *salaam* are visibly one family (s-l-m), the way this book wishes Latin were. That root system is taught as the organizing engine. A recurring thread is Arabic’s long shadow over **Spanish**, another language in this project: the article *al-* smuggled into English *algebra* and *alcohol*, and the sun-letter assimilation still audible in Spanish *azúcar* (from *as-sukkar*) — every such form supplied in full, so no prior knowledge of Spanish is assumed.

How to use this book

Every numbered section is one word, or one small phrase, and takes a few minutes — the length of a queue, an errand, or the walk to the bus. Read them in order the first time through: each section stands on the ones before it, and nothing is used before it has been taught. After that the book becomes reference, and you can open it anywhere.

Say the Arabic out loud wherever you can. The prompts under *Your turn* are written to be spoken, and saying a word is most of what makes it stay. The questions under *Before you move on* carry their own answers in brackets: cover them, answer from memory, then look.

Nothing here is gated behind the alphabet. Each lesson introduces exactly the letters and sounds its own word needs, so you are reading real words from the first page rather than drilling a chart. The whole script is gathered in a reference at the back of the book — somewhere to look things up when you are curious, never a chapter to sit through first.

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Chapter 1

Greetings

The Arabic greetings — and, taught through them, how to read the Arabic script and how the three-consonant **root** builds nearly every word. Each lesson introduces the letters its word needs, so you learn to read the word and understand it at once.

Three facts about the script, and one about the roots

1. **Right to left.** The first letter of a word is on the *right*.
2. **Letters connect** (cursive-style), so a letter's shape shifts a little by position; a few are “one-way” — they join the letter before but not the one after.
3. **Short vowels are usually invisible.** Long vowels (*ā ī ū*) are full letters; the short *a/i/u* between consonants are simply known, not written.

And the engine of the whole language: most Arabic words are a **root** of three consonants carrying a core meaning, poured into fixed vowel **patterns**. The classic is **k-t-b** (writing): *kataba* (he wrote), *kitāb* (book), *kātib* (writer), *maktab* (office = “a place of writing”), *maktaba* (library) — six words, one root. Every greeting below is a root plus a pattern; watch the roots surface.

1.1 سلام (*salām*) — “peace,” the most famous root

The letters in this word

Four letters, read **right to left**: س (*sīn*, “s”), ل (*lām*, “l”), ا (*alif*, long “ā”), م (*mīm*, “m”). Warm up on the tiny word لا (*lā*, “no”) — *lām* then *alif*, fusing into one shape — then read سلام right to left: *s · l · ā · m* → *salām*.

The word, taken apart — its root and its family

سلام (*salām*), “peace.” Root **s-l-m** (*wholeness, safety, peace*) — an enormous family: *salām* (peace), *islām* (submission → peace with God), *muslim* (“one who submits,” the *mu-i-* pattern), *sallama* (to greet). It reaches past Arabic: Hebrew **shalom** is the *same* Semitic root. English meets it as the borrowing *salaam* and the name *Salīm*.

Why it’s said this way

On its own, *salām* is a warm “peace” — and the seed of the full greeting *as-salāmu ‘alaykum*, coming shortly. To say it is to wish the other person peace, not merely to signal “hello.”

1.2 مرحبا (*marḥaban*) — “hello,” i.e. “there’s room for you”

The letters in this word

Three new letters: ب (*bāʾ*, “b,” one dot *below*), ر (*rāʾ*, a tapped “r,” one-way), ح (*ḥāʾ*, a heavy, throaty “h”). With م and ا from *salām*, read باب (*bāb*, “door”), حب (*ḥubb*, “love”), then مرحبا right to left → *marḥaban*.

The word, taken apart — its root and its family

مرحبا (*marḥaban*), the casual “hi.” Root **r-h-b** (*spaciousness*): *raḥuba* (to be wide), *raḥb* (roomy) → *marḥaban* = “[a place of] welcome, there is room for you.” Not an empty sound but a little sentence — as *buenos días* was once a blessing. Reply: *marḥabtayn*, “two welcomes.”

The word, taken apart — its root and its family

Dots on a shared skeleton distinguish many letters: ب / ت / ث (b / t / th) are one shape with one dot below / two above / three above. Learn one skeleton and you often get three letters.

1.3 ال (*al-*) — “the,” hiding in English *algebra*

The letters in this word

No new letters — just ا (alif) and ل (lām), the two you already read in *salām*, written together and attached to the front of a noun.

The word, taken apart — its root and its family

ال (*al-*, “the”). For ~800 years Arabic was the Mediterranean’s language of science and trade, and English and Spanish absorbed its words *with al- attached*: **algebra** (*al-jabr*), **alcohol** (*al-kuḥl*), **algorithm** (*al-Khwārizmī*), **alchemy**, **almanac**. Learning Arabic *al-* is meeting an old friend.

Grammar Lens

Sun letters. Before certain consonants (س *s*, ش *sh*, ن *n*, ر *r*, ت *t*...) the *l* of *al-* assimilates and the letter doubles: *al- + salām* → *as-salām*; *al- + nūr* → *an-nūr*. Before “moon letters” (خ *kh*, ك *k*...) the *l* stays: *al-khayr*. You can hear the rule inside Spanish *azúcar* (from *as-sukkar*).

1.4 السلام عليكم (*as-salāmu ‘alaykum*) — “peace be upon you”

The letters in this word

Three new letters, all in *‘alaykum*: ع (*‘ayn*, a throat-tightening with no English equal — approximate it), ي (*yā’*, “y”), ك (*kāf*, “k”). The rest you can already read: السلام is *al- + salām*.

السلام عليكم = *as-salāmu* (*al- + salām*, sun-letter *s* assimilated) + *‘alaykum* (“upon you [all]”). Literally “the peace [be] upon you” — and note there is

no word for “is”: Arabic sets the two phrases side by side and lets “is” be understood (where Spanish needs *está*).

Why it’s said this way

The universal greeting; its reply is fixed: **وعليكم السلام** (*wa-‘alaykum as-salām*) — “and upon you the peace.” You give peace; it is returned. Any time, any register, real weight — you are wishing *peace*, not saying “hi.”

1.5 صباح الخير (*ṣabāḥ al-khayr*) — “morning of goodness”

The letters in this word

Two new letters: **ص** (*ṣād*, an *emphatic*/heavy “s” — a different letter from **س**) and **خ** (*khāʾ*, a throat-scrape, the same sound as **Spanish j**). With the rest known, read **صباح** (*ṣabāḥ*, “morning”) and **خير** (*khayr*, “goodness”).

The word, taken apart — its root and its family

صباح (*ṣabāḥ*), root **ṣ-b-h** (dawn/waking: *ṣubḥ* dawn, *aṣbaḥa* “to become, reach morning”). **خير** (*khayr*, “good, goodness”), root **kh-y-r**. Together **صباح الخير** = “morning of the goodness” — *al-khayr* keeps its *l* (moon letter **ل**), a clean contrast with *as-salām*.

Why it’s said this way

Reply: **صباح النور** (*ṣabāḥ an-nūr*) — “morning of the *light*” (*al-* + *nūr*, sun-letter *n* assimilated). You wish goodness; they wish you light.

1.6 مساء الخير (*masāʾ al-khayr*) — “evening of goodness”

The letters in this word

One new mark: ء (*hamza*), a glottal stop — the catch in the middle of “uh-oh.” At the end of مساء it gives *masāʾ*. Everything else here you can already read.

The word, taken apart — its root and its family

مساء (*masāʾ*, “evening”), root **m-s-w**: *amsā* “to become, reach evening” — the exact mirror of *aṣḥaḥa*. Arabic names morning and evening as matched events (each with its own “to become” verb), where French *soir* and Spanish *tarde* both merely meant “late.” مساء الخير = “evening of goodness”; reply مساء النور (*masāʾ an-nūr*).

1.7 شكرا (*shukran*) — “thank you”

The letters in this word

Two new letters: ش (*shīn*, “sh” — it is س *plus three dots*) and ك (*kāf*, “k,” met in *‘alaykum*). Read شكرا right to left → *shukran*.

The word, taken apart — its root and its family

شكرا (*shukran*), root **sh-k-r** (*gratitude*): *shukr* (thanks), *shākir* (thankful), *mashkūr* (thanked). Look: *shākir* and *mashkūr* sit in the *exact* patterns as *kātib* (writer) and *maktūb* (written) from the root engine — learn a pattern once, it works on every root. (This same root, through Persian, gave Hindi/Urdu *shukriyā*.) Reply: عفو! (*afwan*), “it’s nothing.”

1.8 The day of greetings

When	Greeting	Reply
casual	<i>marḥaban</i>	<i>marḥabtayn</i>
any time	<i>as-salāmu ‘alaykum</i>	<i>wa-‘alaykum as-salām</i>
morning	<i>ṣabāḥ al-khayr</i>	<i>ṣabāḥ an-nūr</i>
evening	<i>masā’ al-khayr</i>	<i>masā’ an-nūr</i>
thanks	<i>shukran</i>	<i>‘afwan</i>

Read these back right to left before checking: السلام عليكم, مرحبا, سلام. شكرا, مساء الخير, صباح الخير. About a dozen letters, each learned inside a real greeting. Two engines did the work: the three-consonant **root** (s-l-m, sh-k-r) and the attached **al-** with its sun/moon assimilation. Next chapter: introducing yourself (*ismī...*, “my name is”) and how Arabic marks “you” by gender (*anta* / *anti*).

Chapter 2

Introducing Yourself

Now a first real exchange — giving your name, asking for someone else’s, and saying you’re glad to meet them:

اسمي أرُون. (*ismī Arun* — “My name is Arun.”)
ما اسمك؟ (*mā ismuka* — “What is your name?”)

Built from Chapter 1’s letters and roots, each piece taken apart, then assembled.

2.1 اسم (*ism*) — “name”

The letters in this word

No new letters — ا (*alif*), س (*sīn*), م (*mīm*) are all from Chapter 1. Read اسم right to left → *ism*.

The word, taken apart — its root and its family

اسم (*ism*, “name”), root **s–m–w**. It is a **Semitic** word, the cousin of Hebrew *shem* (“name”) — the same pairing you saw with *salām* / *shalom*. It has *no* tie to the Indo-European *name* / Latin *nōmen*: Arabic belongs to a different family entirely, and its word for “name” is its own.

2.2 ي (-ī) — “my,” a letter stuck on the end

The letters in this word

ي (*yāʾ*), met in *‘alaykum*, here does a new job: attached to the end of a noun it means “my.”

The word, taken apart — its root and its family

Arabic doesn’t use a separate word for “my” — it **glues a suffix** onto the noun: اسم (*ism*, “name”) + ي (-ī, “my”) = اسمي (*ismī*, “my name”). This is the same trick as the attached *al-* from Chapter 1: Arabic loves to build meaning by fastening little pieces onto a word, not by stringing separate words together.

2.3 ... اسمي (*ismī ...*) — “my name is...,” with no “is”

اسمي (my name) + name = *ismī ... Ismī Arun.* = “My name is Arun.”

Grammar Lens

No word for “is” — again. Recall from *as-salāmu ‘alaykum* (Ch. 1) that Arabic sets two words side by side and lets “is” be understood. So *ismī Arun* is literally “my-name Arun.” Arabic shares this **zero copula** with the Dravidian languages (Tamil *eṇ peyar Arun*) — a striking meeting of two unrelated families on the same habit.

2.4 أنت (*anta / anti*) — “you,” marked by *gender*

The letters in this word

Two new letters: أ (*alif* with a *hamza* seat, a glottal “a”-start) and ت (*tāʾ*, “t” — the ب/ت/ث skeleton from Ch. 1, two dots above). The final vowel is written only with a mark: أنت *anta*, أنتِ *anti*.

The word, taken apart — its root and its family

أنت is “you” — but Arabic splits it by the listener’s **gender**: *anta* to a man, *anti* to a woman. (Root of the pronoun aside, note the shared Semitic *-ta/-ti* ending, the same *t* that marks “you” in Hebrew *atta/att.*)

Grammar Lens

A different axis of “you.” The European and Dravidian tracks split “you” by *register* (familiar vs. respectful — *tū/vous*, *nī/nīṅaḷ*). Arabic splits it by *gender*: *anta* (to a man) vs. *anti* (to a woman). Same pronoun, a wholly different distinction — you choose by *who you’re talking to*, not how formal you are.

2.5 ما (mā) — “what”

The letters in this word

No new letters: م (*m*) + ا (*alif*, long ā) → ما *mā* — the little word you already read as a warm-up in Chapter 1.

The word, taken apart — its root and its family

ما (*mā*, “what”) is the everyday question-word for things. (Arabic has a second, *mādhā*, for “what” before verbs; *mā* is the one you want before a noun, as in “what [is] your name?”)

2.6 ما اسمك؟ (mā ismuka / ismuki) — “what’s your name?”

ما اسمك = اسم (*ism*, name) + ك (*kāf*, the “your” suffix) — and *it too is gendered*: *ismuka* (a man’s name), *ismuki* (a woman’s). So ما اسمك؟ is literally “**what [is] your-name?**” — no “is,” the possessive glued on, the gender in the suffix.

Grammar Lens

Notice the matched pair: “my name” takes ي (*-ī*), “your name” takes ك (*-ka/-ki*). Answer with *ismī Arun*. The suffixes are the whole grammar

of the exchange.

2.7 تشرفنا (*tasharrafnā*) — “pleased to meet you”

The letters in this word

Uses ت (*tāʾ*, just met), ش (*shīn*) and ر (*rāʾ*) from Ch. 1, plus ف (*fāʾ*, “f”).

The word, taken apart — its root and its family

تشرفنا (*tasharrafnā*), root **sh-r-f** (*honour, nobility*): *sharaf* (honour), *sharīf* (noble — the English borrowing *sherif* of Mecca, and, distantly, the title behind *sheriff*). *tasharrafnā* means literally “**we have been honoured**” — to meet you is presented as an honour received. A more literal option is فرصة سعيدة (*furṣa saʿīda*, “a happy occasion”).

2.8 The whole exchange

Arabic	English
اسمي ميرا.	My name is Mira.
ما اسمك؟	What’s your name?
اسمي أرون.	My name is Arun.
تشرفنا.	Pleased to meet you.

Every piece from the root-and-suffix engine: *ism* (root s-m-w, Hebrew *shem*), the glued *-ī* (“my”) and *-ka/-ki* (“your”), *tasharrafnā* (root sh-r-f, “honour”). And two Arabic habits: it drops “is” entirely (the **zero copula**, shared with the Dravidian languages), and it marks “you” by **gender** (*anta/anti*), not register. Next chapter: *kayfa ḥāluka?* (“how are you?”) and *al-ḥamdu lillāh* — the responding cycle.

Chapter 3

How Are You?

By the end of this chapter: I can ask an Arabic speaker how they are, answer that I am well, and change the ending of the question to match a man or a woman.

The whole how-are-you exchange, run once to a man and once to a woman, with bi-khayr written out by hand.

3.1 ح، خ، ج — the dots trick, on a brand-new body

Back in Lesson 4 you learned a whole family of letters that share one **bowl** and differ only by dots. Arabic does the *same trick* on a **second** skeleton — a curvy **hook-and-tail body** — giving three more common letters. Learn the body once; the dots do the rest, exactly as before.

Script — The hook-and-tail family

Every letter here is the **same shape**: a rounded **hook** at the top flowing into a **tail that drops below the line**. Only the dot changes:

letter	sound	the dot
ح <i>ḥāʾ</i>	ḥ — a deep, breathy “h” (from the throat)	no dot
خ <i>khāʾ</i>	kh — like the <i>ch</i> in Scottish “loch”	one dot above
ج <i>jīm</i>	j — as in “jam”	one dot below

It is the bowl-family idea reborn: one skeleton, the dots deciding everything. Say the dial — **no dot / above / below** → **ḥ / kh / j**.

Script — Draw them

- ح (*ḥāʾ*) — the hook body, then the descending tail; **no dot**. From Phoenician **ḥēth** (“fence”) — the ancestor of Latin **H**.
- خ (*khāʾ*) — the **same** body, plus **one dot above**. (Arabic built *khāʾ* from *ḥāʾ* by adding the dot — no separate Latin cousin, but you already know the shape.)
- ج (*jīm*) — the same body, plus **one dot below**. From Phoenician **gīml** (“camel”) — the great-grandparent of Greek *gamma* and Latin **C/G**.

Script — Where you’ve seen it — خير

You have already read خير (*khayr*, “good/well”) inside the Chapter 1 greeting الخير صباح (*ṣabāḥ al-khayr*, “good morning”). It **opens with** خ — the hook-body plus one dot above. You now know the first letter of a word you’ve been saying since Lesson... one.

Your turn

- *Write it:* the same hook-and-tail body three times, then dot them — ح (none), خ (above), ج (below)
- *Say it:* the dial — “no dot, above, below — ḥ, kh, j”
- *Say it:* “خ opens خير — the ‘good’ in *ṣabāḥ al-khayr*”

Before you move on

What do ح, خ, ج share, and what tells them apart? (One **hook-and-tail body**; the **dots** — none / above / below.) Which sound is خ, and where’s its dot? (**kh**, like *loch*; **one above**.) Which Chapter 1 word opens with خ? (خير, in *ṣabāḥ al-khayr*.) Next: ك (*kāf*) and ر (*rā*) — the last letters you need to write it.

3.2 ك and ر — an angular k, and an r that won’t hold hands

Two more shapes, and then — next lesson — you can write خير. Meet ك (*kāf*, “k”) and ر (*rā*, “r”). One is angular and new; the

other revisits a rule you learned on the very first day.

Script — 𐤀 (kāf) — the angular k

Break it apart:

1. **the body** — an **angular upright**, bending like an open corner (not a curve — a hard angle). 2. **the inner stroke** — a small *hamza*-like flick tucked **inside** the angle.

𐤀 is *kāf*, a clean “k.” From Phoenician **kaph** (“palm of the hand”) — the ancestor of Greek *kappa* and Latin **K**. It joins its neighbours, changing shape by position like the other connectors.

Script — 𐤁 (rā) — the little downward curve that breaks

Break it apart — there’s just *one piece*:

1. **the curve** — a short stroke that **curves down below the baseline** and stops. No dot, no loop.

𐤁 is *rā*, “r.” From Phoenician **rēsh** (“head”) — ancestor of Greek *rho* and Latin **R**. And here is the important rule: like **alif** (Lesson 1), **rā does not join to the letter after it** — it is one of the **six non-joiners**. So *rā* forces the pen to **lift**, just as *alif* did in *سلام*.

Your turn

- *Write it:* 𐤀 — angular body + the inner flick
- *Write it:* 𐤁 — one short downward curve below the line
- *Say it:* “*rā*, like *alif*, **breaks** — no joining the next letter”
- *Say it:* “*kaph* → K, *rēsh* → R — the Phoenician cousins again”

Before you move on

Describe 𐤀: angular or curved, and what sits inside? (**Angular** body with a small **inner stroke**.) What Latin letters descend from *kāf* and *rā*? (**K** and **R**.) What rule does 𐤁 share with **alif**? (It is a **non-joiner** — the pen **lifts** after it.) Next: you assemble خير — and answer “how are you?”

3.3 خير and بخير — writing “good,” and how you say you’re well

Everything comes together. With خ (Lesson 7), ي (Lesson 5), and ر (Lesson 8), you can now write خير (*khayr*, “good”) — the word hiding in every “good morning” you’ve greeted with — and then بخير (*bi-khayr*, “well”), the everyday answer to “how are you?”

Script — Assemble خير — right to left

Write it starting on the **right**, moving **left**:

1. خ ($khā^ʔ$) — the hook-body with **one dot above, reaching left** into...
2. ي ($yā^ʔ$) — joined in the middle (its two dots below), flowing into...
3. ر ($rā$) — the little down-curve. Remember Lesson 8: $rā$ is a **non-joiner**, so it simply ends the word — but $yā^ʔ$ **does** join into it from the right.

Read back, right to left: خ · ي · ر = $kh \cdot \bar{i} \cdot r$ = خير, “good.” (The root **kh-y-r** means “good, best, choice” across Semitic — the same three consonants carry the meaning, vowels laid on top, just like Arabic always works.)

Script — Then بخير — “(I’m) well”

Glue ب (*bi-*, “in / with”) onto the front — $bā^ʔ$ from Lesson 3, its one dot below — and it joins straight into the $khā^ʔ$:

- بخير = $bā^ʔ \cdot khā^ʔ \cdot yā^ʔ \cdot rā$ = **bi-khayr**, literally “**in goodness**” — what you say when someone asks *kayfa ḥāluk?* (“how are you?”).
“*Al-ḥamdu lillāh, bi-khayr*” — “Praise God, (I’m) well.”

You have now written a **real reply** in a real conversation, in your own hand.

Your turn

- *Write it:* خير, right to left — “ $khā^ʔ$ (dot above), $yā^ʔ$, $rā$ — lift”
- *Write it:* بخير — add *bi-* on the right: “ $bā^ʔ$ joins into $khā^ʔ$ ”
- *Say it:* “the root **kh-y-r** = good; *bi-khayr* = ‘in goodness’ = ‘I’m well’”

Before you move on

Spell خير letter by letter, right to left. ($khā^o \cdot yā^o \cdot rā$ — “good.”) Which letter ends it, and does anything join *after* it? ($rā$ — **no**, it’s a non-joiner; the pen lifts.) What does بخير literally mean, and when do you say it? (“**In goodness**” — the answer to “how are you?”, *kayfa ḥāluk?*.) You can now hand-write a greeting *and* its reply — the Arabic script is yours.

3.4 كيف (kayfa) — “how”

Chapter 2 gave you ما ($mā$, “what”). Here is its partner: كيف (*kayfa*, “how”). Two question words, and you can already build with both.

You’ll want to know — The letters in this word

(*Skim if you read Arabic.*) ك ($kāf$) and ي ($yā^o$) you have written — $kāf$ in the writing set, $yā^o$ in اسمي. The last letter, ف ($fā^o$, the *f*), is **new**; the writing track hasn’t reached it yet, so read it for now and draw it later.

Right to left: ك · ي · ف → *kay-fa*.

Note the **ay** in the middle — the $yā^o$ is doing double duty again, this time as part of a diphthong, exactly as it did as a long $\bar{i}$ in *ismī*.

The word, taken apart — its root and its family

كيف is a **question word**, so it doesn’t behave like the root-and-pattern nouns you’ve been meeting — it just *is*. But the letters **k-y-f** do form a root elsewhere:

word	meaning
kayfiyya	quality, manner — literally “ how-ness ”
kayyafa	to adapt, adjust (to make a thing fit <i>how</i> it must be)
takyīf	adaptation — and, in modern Arabic, air conditioning

So the abstract noun for “quality” is built straight from the word “how.” Arabic does this constantly: take a word, run it through a pattern, get a concept.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “*kayfa*” — “how”
- the pair — “مَا *mā* (what) · كَيْفَ *kayfa* (how)”
- “*kayfiyya*” — and hear “how-ness”

Before you move on

What does كَيْفَ mean? (“**How**.”) Which Chapter 2 word is its partner? (مَا, “what”.) Which letter in it is new? (ف, *fāʾ* — the *f*.) What is *kayfiyya*? (“**Quality**” — literally *how-ness*, built from this very word.) Next: the word Arabic asks about when it asks how you are — and it isn’t “you.”

3.5 حال (ḥāl) — “state, condition”

English asks “how are **you**?” Arabic asks about something else entirely — your حال, your *state*. Get this word and the whole question falls open.

You’ll want to know — The letters in this word

(*Skim if you read Arabic.*) Three letters, **all already yours**: ح (*ḥāʾ*, the deep throat *h*, from the hook-family lesson), ا (*alif*), ل (*lām*).

Right to left: ح · ا · ل → ḥāl. And remember from the writing set: *alif* **breaks** the join, so ḥā- then -l.

Why it’s said this way

Here is the payoff. حال comes from the root ḥ-w-l, “**to turn, to change**.” Look what grows from it:

word	meaning	the turning inside
ḥāl	state, condition	how things have turned out
ḥawla	around	turning <i>round</i> something
taḥwīl	transformation, transfer	making something turn into another
ḥawl	a year	one full turn of the seasons
aḥwāl	circumstances (plural of ḥāl)	the way things stand

So a “state” in Arabic is not a fixed thing you *are* — it’s the position you have **turned to**. The language builds “condition” out of motion. Compare what you already know: Spanish *estar* (“to be, temporarily”) came from Latin *stāre*, “to **stand**.” Two languages, two metaphors for the same idea — one **stands**, one **turns**.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “ḥāl” — deep ḥ from the throat, not an English *h*
- “ḥāl · ḥawla · taḥwīl” — hear the root turning
- the contrast — “Arabic **turns**, Spanish *estar* **stands**”

Before you move on

What does حال mean? (“**State, condition.**”) What root is it from, and what does that root mean? (ḥ–w–l, “**to turn, change.**”) So what is a “state,” literally? (**How things have turned.**) What is ḥawl? (“**A year**” — one full turn.) Next: bolt a “your” onto it and you have the question.

3.6 كَيْفَ حَالُكَ؟ (kayfa ḥāluka?) — “how are you?”

Everything in this question is already yours. You are not learning a new phrase — you are **bolting three known pieces together**.

You'll want to know — The assembly

piece	where you met it
كيف <i>kayfa</i> — “how”	last-but-one lesson
حال <i>hāl</i> — “state”	last lesson
ك <i>-ka / -ki</i> — “your”	new , but see below
→ حالك؟ كيف = “ how [is] your state ?”	

Grammar Lens — The suffix you already half-know

In Chapter 2 you attached *ي* (-ī, “my”) to a noun: *ism* → **ismī** (“my name”). The suffix for “**your**” works **identically** — it just clips onto the end:

- حالك *hāluka* — “your state,” said **to a man**
- حالك *hāluki* — “your state,” said **to a woman**

And look at that split: **-ka** to a man, **-ki** to a woman. That is exactly the *أنتَ / أنتِ* (*anta / anti*) division from Chapter 2 — Arabic marking gender, not formality, where Spanish and French mark register. The same *fatha / kasra* mark that flipped *anta* to *anti* flips *hāluka* to *hāluki*. **One letter, one mark, both meanings.**

Grammar Lens — No verb at all

Notice what is **missing**: there is no “is,” no “are.” Just *how* — *your-state*. This is the **zero copula** you met with *اسمي* (“my name [is] ...”): Arabic simply doesn’t need a verb to join a thing to its description.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- to a man — “*kayfa hāluka?*”
- to a woman — “*kayfa hāluki?*”
- the parallel — “*ismī* my name · *hāluka* your state”
- the missing word — “how · your-state — **no 'is'**”

Before you move on

What does كيف حالك؟ literally say? (“**How [is] your state?**”) Which suffix means “your,” and how does it split? (**-ka** to a man, **-ki** to a woman — the *anta/anti* split again.) Which Chapter 2 suffix does it copy? (**-ī**, “my,” as in *ismī*.) What word is absent from the sentence? (“**Is**” — the zero copula.) Next: how to answer.

3.7 بخير (bi-khayr) — “well”

The answer to *kayfa ḥāluka?* — and you have **already written this word by hand**. Nothing here is new; it is two old pieces stuck together.

You’ll want to know — The letters in this word

(Skim if you read Arabic.) ب (*bāʾ*), خ (*khāʾ*), ي (*yāʾ*), ر (*rāʾ*) — every one of them from the writing set, where you assembled *خير* and then *بخير* letter by letter. Right to left: ر · ي · خ · ب.

You’ll want to know — The two pieces

خير (*khayr*) — “**good, goodness.**” You have met it before without being told: it is sitting inside the Chapter 1 greeting *الخير صباح* (*ṣabāḥ al-khayr*, “morning of **the good**”). The greeting was never a fixed lump — it was always *ṣabāḥ* + *al-* + *khayr*.

بـ (*bi-*) — “**in, with.**” A **one-letter preposition**, and like ال (*al-*) from Chapter 1, it does not stand alone: it **glues** onto the front of the next word.

→ *بخير* = *bi-* + *khayr* = “**in goodness.**”

You’ll want to know — What you actually say

- — كيف حالك؟ *kayfa ḥāluka?* (“How is your state?”)
- — شكراً بخير، *bi-khayr, shukran.* (“Well, thank you.”)

Literally: “*In goodness, thanks.*” Not “I am fine” — Arabic doesn’t need the “I am” any more than the question needed an “is.”

You'll want to know — The bi- you have heard before

That same ب opens the most-spoken phrase in the language: الله بسم (*bismillāh*, “in the name of God”) — *bi-* + *ism* (the very word from Chapter 2!) + *allāh*. One tiny letter, doing the same job.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “*bi-khayr*” — “in goodness”
- the callback — “*ṣabāḥ al-khayr ... bi-khayr*”
- the exchange — “*kayfa ḥāluka? — bi-khayr, shukran.*”
- “*bismillāh*” — and find *ism* inside it

Before you move on

What does بخير literally mean? (“**In goodness.**”) Where had you already met *khayr*? (Inside الخير صباح — “morning of the good.”) What kind of word is ب? (A **one-letter preposition** that attaches, like *al-*.) What is missing from the answer, again? (Any word for “**I am.**”) Next: the answer Arabic gives even more often.

3.8 لله الحمد (al-ḥamdu lillāh) — “praise be to God”

Ask an Arabic speaker how they are and this, more often than *bi-khayr*, is what comes back. It also hides the best root story in the chapter.

You'll want to know — The letters

(Skim if you read Arabic.) ا ل م ح د and ه ل ل ه — **every letter is one you have written**: *alif*, *lām*, *ḥā*², *mīm*, *dāl*, *hā*². Nothing new to draw.

You'll want to know — The pieces

piece	meaning	where from
ال <i>al-</i>	“the”	Chapter 1
حمد <i>ḥamd</i>	praise	new , root ḥ–m–d
لي <i>li-</i>	“to, for”	a one-letter preposition, like <i>bi-</i>
الله <i>allāh</i>	God	<i>al-</i> + <i>ilāh</i> , “ the god”

→ الله الحمد = “**the** praise [is] **to** **God**.” Zero copula once more.

Note الله itself: it is *al-* (the article you learned in Chapter 1) fused onto *ilāh*, “a god.” The word is literally “**the** **God**.” Its Semitic cousins are Hebrew *El* and *Elohim* — the same family pairing as *salām* / *shalom* from Chapter 1.

Why it's said this way

ḥ–m–d means “**to** praise.” Run it through Arabic's patterns:

word	pattern meaning
ḥamd	praise (the plain noun)
maḥmūd	praised
ḥamīd	praiseworthy
aḥmad	“more praiseworthy” — the name Ahmad
muḥammad	“the much-praised one” — the name Muhammad

So the most frequently used phrase in the language and the most common given name on earth are built from **the same three consonants**. This is the root engine doing exactly what Chapter 1 promised: three letters, and a whole family of meanings drops out.

You'll want to know — Using it

- — كيف حالك؟ *kayfa ḥāluka?*
- — الله الحمد. *al-ḥamdu lillāh.*

It works as “fine, thanks” — said whether things are going well or badly, which is part of its point.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “*al-ḥamdu lillāh*”
- the root — “*ḥamd · ḥamīd · aḥmad · muḥammad*”
- “*allāh*” — and hear *al-* + *ilāh*, “**the** god”
- the full exchange — “*kayfa ḥāluka? — al-ḥamdu lillāh.*”

Before you move on

What does الحمد لله literally say? (“**The praise [is] to God.**”) What root is *ḥamd* from? (ḥ–m–d, “to praise”). Which two names come out of that root? (**Aḥmad** and **Muḥammad** — “the much-praised.”) What is *allāh* made of? (*al-* + *ilāh* = “**the** god”; cousin of Hebrew *El*.) Next: practice the whole exchange.

3.9 Practice — the whole exchange

Chapter 1 let you greet. Chapter 2 let you introduce yourself. This chapter closes the loop: you can now **ask after someone and answer back**.

The exchange

	Arabic	literally
A	عليكم السلام	peace [be] upon you
B	السلام وعليكم	and upon you, peace
A	حالك؟ كيف	how [is] your state?
B	بخير لله، الحمد	the praise [is] to God — in goodness
B	اسمك؟ ما وأنت؟	and you? what [is] your name?

Read down the right-hand column. **Not one line contains a verb “to be.”** Arabic joins things by putting them next to each other.

You'll want to know — the pieces

phrase	built from
<i>kayfa ḥāluka</i> <i>bi-khayr</i>	<i>kayfa</i> + <i>ḥāl</i> + -ka/-ki bi- + <i>khayr</i> (already inside <i>ṣabāḥ al-khayr</i>)
<i>al-ḥamdu lillāh</i> <i>ismuka</i>	<i>al-</i> + <i>ḥamd</i> + li- + <i>allāh</i> <i>ism</i> + -ka/-ki — the same suffix as <i>ḥāluka</i>

Three tiny attaching pieces — **al-**, **bi-**, **li-** — and two suffixes, **-ī** and **-ka/-ki**. That is most of the chapter.

Grammar Lens — gender

Every “you” in this chapter splits. Say the pair aloud:

to a man

kayfa ḥāluka?
mā ismuka?
anta

to a woman

kayfa ḥāluki?
mā ismuki?
anti

One vowel mark decides — the *fatha* / *kasra* pair from the writing set.

Your turn

- *Say it*: the full exchange, both parts, to a man
- *Say it*: it again, to a woman — every *-ka* becomes *-ki*
- *Write it*: بخير — you have every letter
- *Say it*: the roots met so far — “**s-l-m** peace · **ḥ-w-l** turn · **kh-y-r** good · **ḥ-m-d** praise”

Before you move on

Ask “how are you?” to a woman. (*Kayfa ḥāluki?*) Give both answers. (*Bi-khayr* / *al-ḥamdu lillāh*.) What do *al-*, *bi-* and *li-* have in common? (All **attach** to the next word — they never stand alone.) What single word is absent from every line of the dialogue? (“**Is**” — the zero copula.) Which root gave both a common phrase and a common name? (**ḥ-m-d** — *al-ḥamdu lillāh* and *Muḥammad*.) Next chapter: **farewells** — and the root that started it all comes back.

Chapter 4

Farewells

***By the end of this chapter:** I can close a conversation in Arabic, choosing between ma^ʿa s-salāma and ilā l-liqāʾ.*

The four-chapter conversation end to end – greet, name, how-are-you, farewell – with every -ka swapped to -ki on the second run.

4.1 ع (ʿayn) — the eye that became an O

This is the letter people think of when they think “Arabic.” ع (ʿayn) writes a sound made **deep in the throat** — one English simply does not have. And its history holds the best surprise in the whole alphabet: this consonant is the ancestor of our vowel O.

Script — Draw it

Break it apart — *an open curve, then a bowl*:

1. **the open-mouth curve** on top — like a small **c** opening to the left.
2. **the bowl below**, when ʿayn stands alone or ends a word — a scoop underneath.

Joined in the middle of a word it flattens into a little wedge; standing alone it shows the full curve-over-bowl. It is a **connector**, so it changes coat by position like *sīn* and *lām*.

Script — A third dots-family

You know the **bowl** family (ب/ن/ت/ث) from Lesson 4 and the **hook-and-tail** family (ح/خ/ج) from Lesson 7. ʿayn opens a **third**: its skeleton is

shared with غ (*ghayn*), which is the **same shape plus one dot above**. Same trick, third time — by now you should expect it.

Script — The surprise: ^ʿayn → O

^ʿayn comes from Phoenician **ʿayin**, meaning “**eye**” — and the oldest forms were drawn as one. When the **Greeks** borrowed the Phoenician alphabet, they had **no throat-sound** like ^ʿ. So they did what borrowers do with a sign they can’t use: they **repurposed** it — and turned the eye-shaped letter into the vowel **omicron**, our **O**.

So the round **O** you write is a Phoenician **eye**, and Arabic’s ^ʿayn is the same sign that kept its original consonant job. (Compare the thread so far: ^ʾālep→**A**, bēt→**B**, mem→**M**, kaph→**K**, rēsh→**R** — and now ^ʿayin→**O**.)

Script — Where you’ve heard it

You have been *saying* this sound since Chapter 1: عليكم السلام (*as-salāmu ʿalaykum*) — the ^ʿ in *ʿalaykum* is this letter. And the farewell you’ll write two lessons from now, السلامة مع, opens with it.

Your turn

- *Write it:* ع — the open curve, then the bowl beneath
- *Say it:* the sound, from the throat — as in *ʿalaykum*
- *Say it:* the family — “^ʿayn ع, and *ghayn* غ = the same shape **plus one dot**”
- *Say it:* “^ʿayin = **eye** → the Greeks made it **O**”

Before you move on

Describe ع’s two pieces. (An **open-mouth curve** on top, a **bowl** below when isolated or final.) What did Phoenician ^ʿayin mean, and what letter did the Greeks turn it into? (“**Eye**”; they had no such sound, so they made it the vowel **O**.) Which letter shares its skeleton? (غ *ghayn* — one dot above.) Next: ه and the feminine ending ة.

4.2 ḥ and ʾ — the loop, and the ending that means “feminine”

Two related shapes. ḥ ($h\bar{a}^{\text{ḥ}}$) is a plain “h” — and the most **shape-shifting** letter you’ve met, wearing four genuinely different coats. Then ʾ, a letter built *out of* it, whose whole job is to say one grammatical thing: **this word is feminine**.

Script — ḥ ($h\bar{a}^{\text{ḥ}}$) — the loop that never looks the same

Break it apart — there is really just *one piece*:

1. **the loop** — a closed round body.

But that loop **changes shape a lot by position** more than any letter so far: standing alone it’s a neat circle-ish loop; at the start it opens out; in the middle it becomes a small figure-of-eight pinched in the centre; at the end it trails. Same letter, four faces — the four-coats rule from Lesson 2 taken to its extreme.

From Phoenician **hē** — the ancestor of Greek *epsilon* and Latin **E**. (Another one for the family tree: $^{\text{ḥ}}\bar{a}lep \rightarrow A$, $b\bar{e}t \rightarrow B$, $h\bar{e} \rightarrow \mathbf{E}$, $mem \rightarrow M$, $^{\text{ḥ}}ayin \rightarrow O$.)

Script — ʾ ($t\bar{a}^{\text{ḥ}}$ marbūṭa) — the “tied $t\bar{a}^{\text{ḥ}}$ ”

Now look carefully at this:

- ḥ = $h\bar{a}^{\text{ḥ}}$ ’s loop, **no dots**.
- ʾ = **the same loop** + $t\bar{a}^{\text{ḥ}}$ ’s **two dots above**.

Its name says exactly what it is: **$t\bar{a}^{\text{ḥ}}$ marbūṭa**, “the **tied-up $t\bar{a}^{\text{ḥ}}$** ” — a ت ($t\bar{a}^{\text{ḥ}}$, Lesson 4) whose ends have been **tied into a loop**. It appears **only at the end of a word**, and it is the standard mark of a **feminine** noun or adjective.

You already know its partner: back in Lesson 4 you learned ت with **two dots above**. Put those same two dots on a $h\bar{a}^{\text{ḥ}}$ loop and you get the feminine ending. Nothing new to memorise — just two known pieces combined.

Where you’ve seen it: the farewell **السلامة مع** ($ma^{\text{ḥ}}a s\text{-}sal\bar{a}ma$) ends in ʾ — *salāma* is feminine. That’s the next lesson.

Your turn

- *Write it:* ه — the loop; then try it isolated and final, feel it change
- *Write it:* ð — the same loop, **plus tāʾ's two dots above**
- *Say it:* the name — “tāʾ marbūṭa, the **tied** tāʾ — it marks the feminine”
- *Say it:* “hē → Greek epsilon → Latin **E**”

Before you move on

What makes ه unusual among the letters you've learned? (Its **loop changes shape** dramatically by position — four very different coats.) What is ð made of, and what does its name mean? (hāʾ's loop + **tāʾ's two dots**; “**tied tāʾ**.”) What does ð tell you about a word, and where can it appear? (That it is **feminine**; only at the **end**.) Next: assembling the farewell مع السلامة.

4.3 مع السلامة — the goodbye, and a word you already know

The closing move. مع السلامة (ma^ca s-salāma) is how Arabic says goodbye — literally “**with safety**,” *go in peace*. And the heart of it is a word you wrote **all the way back in Lesson 3**: سلام. Everything since has been leading here.

Script — Part 1 — مع (ma^ca, “with”)

Two letters, both known:

1. م (mīm, Lesson 3) — round head, joining left into...
 2. ع (ʿayn, Lesson 10) — the open curve over its bowl, closing the word.
- مع = ma^ca, “with.”

Script — Part 2 — السلامة (as-salāma, “the safety”)

Look at what this is made of:

- ال — the **al-** (“the”), *alif* + *lām*, both from Lessons 1–2. You’ve read it since Chapter 1 in خيرال and عليكم سلامال.

- سلام — **the exact word you assembled in Lesson 3:** *sīn · lām · alif · mīm*.
- ة — the *tāʾ marbūṭa* from Lesson 11, marking *salāma* as **feminine**.

So السلامة = *al-* + *salām* + *-a*. You are not learning a new word; you are **adding two edges** to one you already own.

Script — The root s-l-m, one more time

salām, *salāma*, *islām*, *muslim* — all from the Semitic root **s-l-m**, “peace, safety, wholeness.” The greeting you learned first (عليكم السلام, “peace be upon you”) and the farewell you learn last (السلامة مع, “with safety”) come from the **same three consonants**. Arabic opens and closes a conversation with one idea.

Script — Assemble it — right to left

1. م then ع → مع 2. lift; ل + ل (the *al-*), the *lām* joining into... 3. ل · س · ل — and remember the لا ligature, and that *alif* **breaks**... 4. م, then ة to close.

→ السلامة مع

Your turn

- Write it: مع — *mīm* into ^cayn
- Write it: السلامة — “the *al-*, then your Lesson-3 word, then the feminine ة”
- Say it: “*ma^ca s-salāma* — **with safety**”
- Say it: the bookend — “عليكم السلام to greet, السلامة مع to part — same root **s-l-m**”

Before you move on

What does السلامة مع literally mean? (“**With safety**.”) Which earlier word sits inside السلامة, and what was added? (سلام from Lesson 3 — plus ال in front and ة behind.) What does the final ة signal? (*salāma* is **feminine**.) What root ties the first greeting to the last farewell? (**s-l-m** — peace/safety.) You can now hand-write an Arabic conversation from hello to goodbye.

4.4 ع (ma^ca) — “with”

Two letters, both already yours, and a word that will carry the whole chapter.

You’ll want to know — The letters

(*Skim if you read Arabic.*) م (*mīm*) from Lesson 3 of the writing set, and ع (*‘ayn*) from Lesson 10 — the throat sound whose Phoenician ancestor meant “**eye**,” and which the Greeks recycled into the vowel **O**.

Right to left: م · ع → ma^ca. The *‘ayn* is not a vowel; it is a constriction deep in the throat. Take your time with it.

You’ll want to know — The word

ع (ma^ca) = “**with**, together with.”

It is a **preposition**, and unlike ل (*al-*) or ب (*bi-*) from Chapter 3, it is a **free-standing word** — it does not glue onto the next one. Compare:

	attaches?
ل <i>al-</i> “the”	yes
ب <i>bi-</i> “in/with”	yes
ل <i>li-</i> “to”	yes
ع ma ^c a “with”	no

So Arabic has *two* words touching on “with”: the one-letter ب (*bi-*, “in/by means of,” as in *bi-khayr*) and the full word ع (ma^ca, “accompanied by”). *Bi-khayr* is “**in** goodness”; ma^ca is standing **next to** something.

Why it’s said this way

ma^ca ← Semitic **‘imma*, and its Hebrew cousin is עִם (*‘im*), “with.” The same pairing you met with **salām** / **shalom** in Chapter 1 and **ism** / **shem** in Chapter 2. Three chapters, three cousins — the family resemblance is systematic, not a coincidence.

Your turn

- Say it: “ma^ca” — the *‘ayn* from the throat
- Say it: the contrast — “*bi-khayr* **in** goodness · ma^ca **with**”
- Say it: the cousin — “ma^ca · Hebrew *‘im*”

- Write it: مع — mīm joining into ʿayn

Before you move on

What does مع mean? (“**With.**”) Does it attach to the next word, like *al-* and *bi-*? (**No** — it stands alone.) What is the difference between *bi-* and *maʿa*? (*Bi-* = “**in/by** means of”; *maʿa* = “**accompanied by**.”) What is its Hebrew cousin? (*ʿim.*) Next: the word it goes with — and you already know most of it.

4.5 السلامة (as-salāma) — “the safety”

This looks like a long new word. It isn’t. It is **one word you learned in Chapter 1** with a piece added at each end.

You’ll want to know — Taking it apart

piece	what it is	met in
ال	<i>al-</i> , “the”	Ch. 1
سلام	<i>salām</i> , “peace”	Ch. 1 — the very first word
ة	<i>tāʾ marbūʿa</i> , feminine ending	writing Lesson 11

→ السلامة = *al-* + *salām* + *-a* = “**the safety**.”

Every letter is one you have already written by hand.

You’ll want to know — The pattern that changed the meaning

Arabic doesn’t just add endings — it pours a root into a **shape**. Here the root **s-l-m** goes into the pattern *faʿāla*, which turns a thing into **the state of being that thing**:

word	meaning
salām	peace
salāma	safety, soundness, wellbeing — <i>the state of being at peace</i>

Same three consonants, one new shape, a new but related word. This is the engine Chapter 1 promised, working in front of you.

You'll want to know — Two small rules, both already learned

1. The sun letter. *S* (س) is a **sun letter**, so the *l* of *al-* assimilates to it: written الس, but said **as**-salāma, not *al-salāma*. The same thing happens in عليكم لام الس — the greeting you have said since Chapter 1.

2. The feminine ة. *Tā' marbūṭa* marks *salāma* as **feminine**. Arabic abstract nouns very often are.

Your turn

- Say it: “*as-salāma*” — with the doubled *s*, not *al-s*
- Say it: the build — “*salām ... salāma ... as-salāma*”
- Say it: the pattern — “peace → **the state of** peace”
- Write it: السلامة

Before you move on

What three pieces make السلامة? (*al-* + *salām* + ة.) What did the *fa^cāla* pattern do to the meaning? (Turned “peace” into “**the state of** being at peace” — safety.) Why is it *as-salāma* and not *al-salāma*? (س is a **sun letter**; the *l* assimilates.) What does the ة tell you? (The word is **feminine**.) Next: put *ma^ca* in front of it.

4.6 السلامة مع (*ma^ca s-salāma*) — “goodbye”

Put the last two lessons together and the farewell falls out. You have already **hand-written** this phrase; now it means something.

You'll want to know — The assembly

مع (*ma^ca*, “with”) + السلامة (*as-salāma*, “the safety”) → السلامة مع
— “**with safety**.”

Said as one run: *ma^ca s-salāma* — the *a* of *ma^ca* swallows the *al-*’s vowel, and the sun-letter rule doubles the *s*.

It is not “goodbye” in the English sense of a plain sign-off. It is a **wish**: *go in safety*.

You’ll want to know — The circle closes

Look at what Chapter 1 opened with and what Chapter 4 closes with:

	phrase	root
first greeting	عليكم السلام <i>as-salāmu</i> <i>ʿalaykum</i>	s-l-m
last farewell	مع السلامة <i>ma^ʿa</i> <i>s-salāma</i>	s-l-m

The same three consonants. Arabic begins and ends a conversation with one idea — peace, safety, wholeness. The root engine you met in the very first lesson has been running the whole time; here it simply comes back round.

The family, one more time: *salām* (peace), *salāma* (safety), *islām* (submission, i.e. entering peace), *muslim* (one who does so).

You’ll want to know — English does the same trick

Goodbye looks like a single word. It is worn down from *God be with ye*. So the English farewell is also built on “**with**” — you are being commended to something protective as you go.

language	farewell	literally
Arabic	<i>ma^ʿa s-salāma</i>	“ with safety”
English	<i>goodbye</i>	“God be with ye”
Spanish	<i>adiós</i>	“to God”
French	<i>adieu</i>	“to God”

Four languages, one instinct: as someone leaves, hand them over to safekeeping.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “*ma^ʿa s-salāma*”
- the bookend — “*as-salāmu ʿalaykum ... ma^ʿa s-salāma*”
- the root aloud — “s · l · m”
- “goodbye ← God be **with** ye”

Before you move on

What does مع السلامة literally mean? (“**With safety.**”) What root is it built on, and where have you met that root before? (**s-l-m** — the Chapter 1 greeting *as-salāmu* ‘alaykum, and *salām* itself.) So what does Arabic open and close a conversation with? (**The same idea** — peace/safety.) What is English *goodbye* worn down from? (“**God be with ye.**”) Next: a second farewell, and a word Spanish borrowed.

4.7 اللقاء (ilā l-liqāʾ) — “see you”

The other everyday farewell — and the one with a surprise waiting inside Spanish.

You’ll want to know — A note on the letters

(*Skim if you read Arabic.*) Two pieces here are **beyond what the writing track has covered**, so read them for now and draw them later:

- ق (*qāf*) — a *k* made far back against the soft palate, deeper than ك (*kāf*). It is **not** in the letter set you have been writing from.
- ي in إلى — this is *alif maqṣūra*, “shortened alif”: it wears **yā’s skeleton with no dots** and is pronounced as a long *ā*. You already know from writing Lessons 4–5 that dots are what separate letters sharing a body; this is that same principle, taken one step further.

The rest — ا ل ع — you have written.

You’ll want to know — The two pieces

piece	meaning
إلى <i>ilā</i>	“to, until”
اللقاء <i>al-liqāʾ</i>	“the meeting”

→ اللقاء إلى = “**until the meeting.**”

لقاء (*liqāʾ*) comes from the root **l-q-y**, “**to meet.**” The final ع is the *hamza* from writing Lesson 6 — a glottal stop, a real consonant here, not decoration.

Note ل is a sun letter too, so *al-liqāʾ* doubles the *l*, just as *as-salāma* doubled the *s*.

Why it's said this way

Spanish says goodbye like this:

hasta luego — “**until** later” *hasta mañana* — “**until** tomorrow”

Same shape as *ilā l-liqāʿ*: “**until**” + a **future point**. But it goes further — Spanish *hasta* is itself an **Arabic loanword**, from *ḥattā* (“until”). Of the roughly four thousand Arabic words Spanish took during the eight centuries of al-Andalus, most are nouns; *hasta* is one of the rare borrowed **function words**.

So Spanish did not merely copy the pattern — it borrowed the very word that builds it.

language	farewell	shape
Arabic	<i>ilā l-liqāʿ</i>	until + the meeting
Spanish	<i>hasta luego</i>	until (← <i>ḥattā</i>) + later
French	<i>à bientôt</i>	to + soon
Italian	<i>a presto</i>	to + soon

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “*ilā l-liqāʿ*” — double the *l*
- the two farewells — “*maʿa s-salāma* · *ilā l-liqāʿ*”
- the loan — “*hasta* ← *ḥattā*”
- the root — “**l · q · y** — to meet”

Before you move on

What does **إلى اللقاء** literally say? (“**Until the meeting.**”) What root is *liqāʿ* from? (**l-q-y**, “to meet.”) Which two letters here has the writing track **not** reached? (**ق** *qāf*, and **ي** *alif maqṣūra*.) What is *alif maqṣūra*? (**Yāʿ’s body with no dots**, pronounced long *ā*.) Which Spanish word for “until” came from Arabic? (***Hasta*** ← *ḥattā*.) Next:

practise the whole conversation, hello to goodbye.

4.8 Practice — the whole conversation

Four chapters. Greet, introduce, ask after someone, part. Here it all is in one piece.

You'll want to know — The full exchange

	Arabic	literally
A	عليكم السلام	peace [be] upon you
B	السلام وعليكم	and upon you, peace
A	اسمك؟ ما	what [is] your name?
B	تشرفنا ... اسمي.	my name [is] ..., we are honoured
A	حالك؟ كيف	how [is] your state?
B	بخير لله، الحمد.	the praise [is] to God — in goodness
A	السلامة مع	with safety
B	اللقاء إلى	until the meeting

Read the right-hand column top to bottom. **Not one line contains a verb “to be.”** The zero copula has held for four chapters.

Why it's said this way

Everything you have learned sits on a handful of three-consonant roots:

root	meaning	words you know
s-l-m	peace, safety	<i>salām, as-salāmu</i> <i>‘alaykum, salāma,</i> <i>ma^{‘a} s-salāma</i>
s-m-w	name	<i>ism, ismī, ismuka</i>
ḥ-w-l	to turn	<i>ḥāl, kayfa ḥāluka</i>
kh-y-r	good	<i>ṣabāḥ al-khayr,</i> <i>bi-khayr</i>
ḥ-m-d	to praise	<i>al-ḥamdu lillāh,</i> <i>Muḥammad</i>
l-q-y	to meet	<i>liqāʾ, ilā l-liqāʾ</i>

Six roots. A whole conversation.

Grammar Lens — The small attaching pieces

piece	job	example
ال <i>al-</i>	the	<i>al-khayr</i>
بـ <i>bi-</i>	in / by	<i>bi-khayr</i>
لـ <i>li-</i>	to	<i>lillāh</i>
ـي <i>-ī</i>	my	<i>ismī</i>
كـ <i>-ka / -ki</i>	your (m./f.)	<i>ismuka, ḥāluki</i>

And مع *ma^ca*, the one that **doesn't** attach.

Your turn

- *Say it*: the full dialogue, both parts, addressing a **man**
- *Say it*: it again to a **woman** — every *-ka* becomes *-ki*
- *Write it*: مع السلامة — every letter is one you have drawn
- *Say it*: the bookend — “السلام to open, السلامة to close”

Before you move on

Give a complete greeting-to-farewell exchange. (The dialogue above.) Which root opens **and** closes it? (**s-l-m**.) Which piece of the chapter doesn't glue onto the next word? (مع *ma^ca*.) What single word is absent from every literal translation? (“**Is**” — the zero copula.) Which Spanish word came from Arabic *ḥattā*? (**Hasta**.) You can now hold — and hand-write — a short Arabic conversation from beginning to end.

Chapter 5

Yes and No

By the end of this chapter: I can answer a question in Arabic with $na^c am$ or $lā$, and write $lā$ as the single joined $lām$ - $alif$ shape.

Say the yes/no pair and form $lā$ as one $lām$ - $alif$ ligature rather than two separate letters.

5.1 نعم ($na^c am$) — yes

A short word to mean yes — with one sound English simply doesn't have.

You'll want to know — The word

نعم = **yes**, said **$na^c am$** . Arabic reads **right to left**, so its three letters run:

ن (n) · ع (c) · م (m) → **$na^c a-m$**

The middle letter ع is the famous **$^c ayn$** — a *pharyngeal* sound made deep in the throat, a tight squeeze with no English equivalent. Don't worry about mastering it today; just know that the little apostrophe-like mark in $na^c am$ (the c) is standing in for a real, throaty consonant, not a pause.

You'll want to know — Saying yes, and other ways

$na^c am$ is the clear, standard **yes** — polite and safe anywhere. Two neighbours you'll also hear:

- أَجَل (*ajal*) — a more formal, emphatic “yes, indeed.”

- In everyday speech, many dialects say أيووة (*aywa*) for a casual “yeah.”

And a useful twist: said as a question, **na^cam?** also means “**pardon?** / **you were saying?**” — the same stretch English gives “yes?”

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “na^cam” — feel the ع squeeze in the middle of the throat
- right to left — م · ع · ن
- as a question — “na^cam?” = “pardon?”

Before you move on

How do you say yes in Arabic? (**na^cam**, نعم.) Which way does the script run? (**Right to left**.) What is the ع in the middle — a pause or a sound? (A **sound** — the throaty *‘ayn*, with no English match.) What does *na^cam?* mean when you say it as a question? (“**Pardon?**”)

5.2 لا (lā) — no

Two letters, one long vowel — and one of the most recognisable words in the language.

You’ll want to know — The word

لا = **no**, said **lā** (a long *aah*). It’s just two letters — ل (l) + ا (the long *ā*, *alif*) — but they’re written joined into one sweeping shape, لا, a *lam-alif* that Arabic always writes as a single unit. It’s one of the first letter-joins learners recognise on sight.

You’ll want to know — More than an answer

lā isn’t only the reply “no.” It is Arabic’s great word of **negation**, and it opens the most-spoken sentence in the language — the first half of the *shahada*:

لا إله إلا الله — *lā ilāha illā llāh* — “**There is no** god but God.”

That opening **lā** is your word. The same *lā* also negates present-tense verbs — لا أعرف *lā aʿrif*, “I do **not** know” — so, like Spanish *no*, one little word is both the answer “no” and the sentence’s “not.”

Grammar Lens — Yes and no, together

You now have the pair:

	Arabic	said
yes	نعم	<i>naʿam</i>
no	لا	<i>lā</i>

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “lā” — a long, open *aah*
- the join — ج + ل written as one, لا
- the pair — “naʿam / lā”

Before you move on

How do you say no in Arabic? (**lā**, لا.) What two letters make it, and how are they written? (ج + ل, joined as a single *lam-alif* لا.) Which famous sentence does *lā* open? (The *shahada* — *lā ilāha illā llāh*.) Besides “no,” what job does *lā* do? (It **negates verbs** — *lā aʿrif*, “I don’t know.”)

Chapter 6

Please

By the end of this chapter: I can attach *min faḍlik* to a request in Arabic and change its ending for a man or a woman.

Say min faḍlik with the heavy dād, take it apart as 'from your grace', and offer law samaḥt as the alternative.

6.1 فضلك من (*min faḍlik*) — please

Arabic doesn't say "please" — it asks for something *from your grace*.

You'll want to know — The phrase

فضلك من — read right to left, **min faḍlik** — is two pieces:

من (*min*, "from") + فضلك (*faḍl* + *-ik/-ak*, "your grace/bounty")
→ "from your grace."

faḍl is a warm, weighty word — "grace, favour, bounty, generosity" (you'll meet it as the name *Faḍl*). Saying *min faḍlik* casts the request as drawing on the other person's generosity — not a command, a courtesy.

Grammar Lens — A gender note (Arabic marks "you")

The ending changes with **whom you address** — and, unwritten, only the vowel moves:

- to a **woman**: *min faḍlik* (the ة said *-ik*)
- to a **man**: *min faḍlak* (the ة said *-ak*)

The spelling **فضلك** is the same for both; the short vowel that distinguishes them isn't normally written. One sound to respect: the **ض** (*ḍ*) is an **emphatic** d, said with a heavier, deeper tongue than a plain *d*.

You'll want to know — Another everyday “please”

Just as common, especially getting someone's attention:

سمحت لو — *law samaḥt* — literally “**if you permit**” (*law* “if” + *samaḥt* “you permitted”). Same politeness, a different image — permission rather than grace.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “min faḍlik” — feel the heavy **ض**
- taken apart — “from your grace”
- the alternative — “law samaḥt” = “if you permit”

Before you move on

How do you say please in Arabic? (**min faḍlik**, **من فضلك**.) What does it literally mean? (“**From your grace**” — *faḍl* = grace/bounty.) What changes between saying it to a man vs a woman? (The **ل** ending — *-ak* to a man, *-ik* to a woman; spelling unchanged.) What's the other common “please,” and what does it mean? (**law samaḥt** — “if you permit.”)

Chapter 7

Sorry

By the end of this chapter: I can apologise in Arabic with *āsif* or *āsifa*, choosing the form that matches who is speaking.

Say the apology twice – āsif for a man, āsifa for a woman – then the ungendered ma^cdhira.

7.1 آسف / آسفة (āsif / āsifa) — sorry

You already know *من فضلك*, “please.” Arabic’s word for “sorry” teaches a new lesson entirely: it isn’t a fixed word at all — **it changes with the speaker.**

The word, taken apart — its root and its family

آسف (*āsif*, said by a man) and آسفة (*āsifa*, said by a woman) both mean “**sorry**.” They come from the verb أَسَفَ (*asifa*), “to grieve, to be filled with regret” — so saying *āsif* is describing yourself as *grieved* / *regretful*, the way you’d say “I am tired” or “I am happy.”

That’s the key: آسف **is an adjective**, and Arabic adjectives **agree with the gender of the person they describe**. A man says آسف; a woman says آسفة — the extra *ṣ* (*tā^ʿ marbūṭa*) is the everyday feminine ending you’ll meet across Arabic adjectives. English “sorry” never changes no matter who says it; Arabic “sorry” always tells you the speaker’s gender in the same breath.

Why it's said this way

For a quick, **ungendered** “excuse me / pardon” — squeezing past someone, interrupting, a light apology — Arabic reaches for معذرة (*ma^cdhira*), from the root ر-ذ-ع (“to excuse”), the same root as عذر (*ʿudhr*, “an excuse”) and the verb يعتذر (*ya^ctadhīru*, “to apologize”). Unlike *āsif/āsifa*, معذرة **doesn't change with gender** — it's a noun, not an adjective, so anyone says the same word.

Use آسف/أسفة when you mean a real, felt “I'm sorry” (and remember to match your own gender); reach for معذرة for the light, everyday “pardon me.”

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- a man says — “*āsif*”
- a woman says — “*āsifa*”
- the ungendered one — “*ma^cdhira*” = excuse me / pardon

Before you move on

What's unusual about آسف / أسفة compared to English “sorry”? (**It's a gendered adjective** — *āsif* for a man, *āsifa* for a woman — where English never changes.) What root gives *āsif*, and what does it mean? (أسف **asafa**, “to grieve, regret.”) What's the ungendered word for a quick “excuse me,” and what root is it from? (معذرة **ma^cdhira**, from ر-ذ-ع “to excuse.”)

Chapter 10

Family

By the end of this chapter: I can name my father, mother, brother and sister in Arabic.

Say akh and ukht, show how ukht is built from the same root plus a feminine -t, and place both beside their Hebrew cousins.

10.1 أب, أم (ab, umm) — father and mother

Two short, ancient words — each just two or three letters — sitting at the root of Semitic family vocabulary across several languages, not just Arabic.

The word, taken apart — its root and its family

- أب (*ab*) = “**father**.” A short, ancient Semitic root, cousin of Hebrew אב (*av*) and Aramaic אבא (*abba*) — the very word behind “**Abba, Father**” in the New Testament.
- أم (*umm*) = “**mother**.” Equally ancient, cousin of Hebrew אם (*em*).

These aren’t borrowings between Arabic and Hebrew — both descend from the same ancient Semitic family vocabulary, the way *pater* and English *father* are cousins through PIE rather than one copying the other.

Why it's said this way

أم stays productive in everyday Arabic naming: أم + a child's name forms a **kunya**, an honorific “**mother of** _____” (and أبو, *abū*, does the same for fathers — “**father of** _____”). Someone might be known publicly as *Umm Khālīd*, “mother of Khālīd,” rather than by their own given name — a naming custom still very much alive today.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “ab” — father — then “umm,” mother
- the Hebrew cousins — “ab/av, umm/em”
- the naming pattern — “Umm + [child's name]” = mother of _____

Before you move on

What are Arabic's words for father and mother? (أب **ab**, أم **umm**.) What are their Hebrew cousins? (**av**, **em** — not borrowings, both from the same ancient Semitic root.) What naming pattern does **umm** still form today? (**Umm** + [child's name], “mother of _____,” a living honorific.)

10.2 أخ, أخت (akh, ukht) — brother and sister

Unlike the color words you just learned (a whole reshaped template for masculine/feminine), siblings here use the **simplest** possible gender marker.

The word, taken apart — its root and its family

- أخ (*akh*) = “**brother**” — another short, ancient Semitic root, cousin of Hebrew אַח (*ach*).
- أخت (*ukht*) = “**sister**” — the **same root**, plus a plain feminine -ت (-*t*) ending, cousin of Hebrew אחות (*achot*).

So *ukht* isn't a separate word — it's *akh* wearing the ordinary feminine

ending, the simple pattern you already know from آسف/أسفة (*āsif/āsifa*, “sorry”), not the elaborate colors template.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “akh” — brother — then “ukht,” sister
- the shared root plus a simple ending — akh + -t
- the Hebrew cousins — “akh/ach, ukht/achot”

Before you move on

What are Arabic’s words for brother and sister? (أخ **akh**, أخت **ukht**.)
 How is *ukht* built from *akh*? (**The same root, plus a plain feminine -ت ending** — the simple pattern, not the colors’ elaborate template.) What are their Hebrew cousins? (**ach, achot**.)

Chapter 11

Head and Hand

By the end of this chapter: I can name the head and the hand in Arabic.

Say yad, set it against its near-identical Hebrew twin, and contrast how much further raʾs drifted.

11.1 رأس (raʾs) — the head

One more ancient Semitic root — and a word still hard at work in modern political vocabulary, the same way Latin’s *caput* is in English.

You’ll want to know — The word

رأس (raʾs) = “head” — an ancient Semitic root, cousin of Hebrew ראש (rosh), the very word inside **Rosh Hashanah**, “head of the year.”

Why it’s said this way

Arabic builds رئيس (raʾīs), “**president, chief, head [of an organization],**” directly on this same root — literally “the one who is the head.” That’s exactly the move English makes with Latin *caput*: **captain** (“head” of a unit), **capital** (“head” city). Different language families, the same very human idea — the person or place “at the head” is the one in charge.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “raʿs” — head
- “raʿīs” — president, literally “the head [one]”
- the Hebrew cousin — “raʿs / rosh”

Before you move on

What does رأس mean, and what’s its Hebrew cousin? (“**Head**” — cousin of **rosh**, as in Rosh Hashanah.) What word is built on it for “president,” and what does it literally mean? (رئيس *raʿīs*, “the head [one]” — the same “head = leader” idea as English *captain/capital* from Latin *caput*.)

11.2 يد (yad) — the hand

Some words wear their age lightly — worn down, reshaped, disguised. This one hasn’t changed much at all.

You’ll want to know — The word

يد (*yad*) = “**hand**” — a short, ancient Semitic root. Its Hebrew cousin is spelled and pronounced almost **identically**: יד (*yad*). Where *raʿs/rosh* show a family resemblance, *yad/yad* is closer to twins — one of the more strikingly unchanged shared words across the whole Semitic family.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “yad” — hand
- the Hebrew twin — “yad” — almost the same word
- contrast — “raʿs/rosh” changed more than “yad/yad” did

Before you move on

What does يد mean? (“**Hand**.”) How does it compare to its Hebrew cousin? (**Nearly identical** — both *yad* — one of the more strikingly unchanged shared words across the Semitic family.)

Chapter 12

Seasons

By the end of this chapter: I can name the four seasons in Arabic and say why the Islamic months do not stay inside them.

Say *rabīʿ*, *ṣayf*, *kharīf*, *shitāʾ*, then explain the lunar calendar’s drift against the solar seasons.

12.1 ربيع, صيف, خريف, شتاء — the four seasons

Four words for the turning year — and a genuine reminder that the tidy four-season picture is a **temperate-climate** habit of mind, not a universal one.

You’ll want to know — The four seasons

Arabic	meaning
ربيع (<i>rabīʿ</i>)	spring
صيف (<i>ṣayf</i>)	summer
خريف (<i>kharīf</i>)	autumn
شتاء (<i>shitāʾ</i>)	winter

Why it’s said this way

ربيع (*rabīʿ*) does double duty: it also names **two months** of the Islamic calendar, **Rabīʿ al-Awwal** and **Rabīʿ al-Thānī** (“first/second Rabīʿ”). That’s worth pausing on, because the **Islamic calendar is lunar** — its months drift across all four solar seasons over roughly a 33-year cycle, unmoored from any actual spring. So a month named “Rabīʿ” won’t reliably fall in spring at all; the name is a fossil from

an earlier calendar, kept even as the lunar calendar carried the months loose from the seasons they were once named for.

More broadly: the tidy four-season year assumes a temperate climate with four clearly distinct weather patterns. Much of the Arabic-speaking world spans very different climates — desert, Mediterranean, tropical — where a strict four-way split maps onto lived experience less cleanly than it does further north. The four words above are the standard Modern Standard Arabic vocabulary, useful and real, but not necessarily the only or most natural way every Arabic-speaking region actually experiences the year.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “rabī^c, ṣayf, kharīf, shitā³” — spring, summer, autumn, winter
- the calendar twist — “rabī^c” also names two Islamic months
- the honest note — lunar months drift free of the solar seasons

Before you move on

What does ربيع do besides name a season? (**Names two Islamic calendar months**, Rabī^c al-Awwal/al-Thānī.) Why don’t those months reliably fall in spring? (**The Islamic calendar is lunar** — its months drift across all four seasons over a ~33-year cycle.) Is the four-season frame equally natural everywhere Arabic is spoken? (**Not necessarily** — it fits temperate climates better than the desert/tropical/Mediterranean climates found across much of the Arabic-speaking world.)

Chapter 13

Water and Bread

By the end of this chapter: I can name water and bread in Arabic and say which of the two sits on a regular root.

Say $māʔ$ with its irregular plural $miyāh$, then $khubz$ from the clean root $kh-b-z$.

13.1 ماء, خبز ($māʔ$, $khubz$) — water and bread

Two everyday words — and a study in contrasts: one of them is one of Arabic’s genuinely **oddest** common nouns, and the other is about as **regular** as a word gets.

You’ll want to know — ماء — **an old, irregular word**

ماء ($māʔ$) = “**water**.” This word is short but **irregular**: its plural (مياه, $miyāh$) and the forms it takes when attached to another noun don’t follow Arabic’s ordinary noun patterns the way most words do. Words this basic — for water, fire, blood, mouth — are often among the oldest in any language family, and old words wear their irregularities proudly; they were already worn smooth by daily use long before the grammar of the rest of the language settled into its regular patterns.

You’ll want to know — خبز — **clean, regular, and freshly made**

خبز ($khubz$) = “**bread**” — built cleanly on the root $kh-b-z$ (خب-ب-ز), “**to bake**.” Where $māʔ$ is a fossil, $khubz$ is transparent: the noun for the baked thing, straight from the verb for baking it.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “mā” — water — then “miyāh,” its irregular plural
- “khubz” — bread — from kh-b-z, “to bake”
- the contrast — one word is a worn-smooth fossil, the other freshly transparent

Before you move on

What’s unusual about ماء? (It’s **genuinely irregular** — its plural *miyāh* and attached forms don’t follow the ordinary pattern, typical of very old, basic words.) What root is خبز built on, and what does that root mean? (ز-ب-خ, “to bake.”)

Chapter 14

Months

***By the end of this chapter:** I can name the months in Arabic and tell the borrowed civil calendar apart from the Islamic one.*

Say the Latin-sounding civil months, then the first Hijri months, and state what each calendar is used for.

14.1 ديسمبر to يناير — Latin names, borrowed whole, running beside a second calendar

Here's a genuinely different kind of honesty this lesson needs: Arabic doesn't have **one** answer to "what are the months called" — it has **two full calendars**, used for different purposes, side by side.

You'll want to know — Gregorian months

For the everyday, civil, solar calendar, Modern Standard Arabic simply **borrow**s the familiar Latin-derived month names you already know from Spanish/French/English:

Arabic	≈
يناير (<i>yanāyir</i>)	January
فبراير (<i>fabrāyir</i>)	February
مارس (<i>māris</i>)	March
أبريل (<i>abrīl</i>)	April
مايو (<i>māyū</i>)	May
يونيو (<i>yūniyū</i>)	June
يوليو (<i>yūliyū</i>)	July
أغسطس (<i>aghustus</i>)	August
سبتمبر (<i>sibtambir</i>)	September
أكتوبر (<i>uktūbar</i>)	October
نوفمبر (<i>nūfambir</i>)	November
ديسمبر (<i>dīsambir</i>)	December

You can hear the Latin (and French) originals right through the Arabic sounds — this is a straightforward, recent borrowing for civil/business use, not an ancient Arabic-invented system.

One more honest wrinkle: these Latin-derived names are the everyday convention in Egypt, the Gulf, and much pan-Arab media — but the Levant and Iraq (Syria, Lebanon, Jordan, Palestine, Iraq) traditionally use a **third**, completely different set for these same twelve solar months, of **Syriac** origin: الثاني كانون (*Kānūn al-Thānī*, January), شباط (*Shubāt*, February), آذار (*Ādhār*, March), and so on. So depending on the country, an Arabic speaker’s civil-calendar month name might come from Latin *or* from Syriac — a third naming system, not just two.

Why it’s said this way

For **religious life** — Ramadan, Hajj, and the Islamic calendar generally — Arabic uses an entirely **separate** set of month names, from the **lunar Hijri calendar**: محرم (*Muḥarram*), صفر (*Ṣafar*), ربيع الأول/الثاني (*Rabī^c al-Awwal/al-Thānī* — the very “Rabī^c” from the seasons lesson), and eight more, none of which correspond to a fixed solar month. Because the Hijri calendar has **no leap-month correction**, these twelve lunar months drift steadily across all four solar seasons over a roughly 33-year cycle — so Ramadan, for instance, doesn’t fall in the same season every year.

Two calendars, two jobs: the borrowed Latin names for the ordinary business week, the older lunar names for religious observance.

14.1. 67ديسمبر نوفمبر أكتوبر سبتمبر أغسطس يوليو يونيو مايو أبريل مارس فبراير يناير

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “yanāyir, fabrāyir, mārīs” — January, February, March — hear the Latin
- the second calendar — “Muḥarram, Ṣafar, Rabīʿ al-Awwal” — entirely different names
- the honest point — two calendars, two purposes, both in everyday use

Before you move on

Where do Arabic’s civil month names (*yanāyir, mārīs...*) come from? (**Borrowed Latin/European names**, recent civil-calendar loans.) What runs alongside them for religious life? (**The Hijri lunar calendar**, with its own entirely different 12 month names — *Muḥarram, Ṣafar, Rabīʿ al-Awwal...*) Why do Hijri months drift across the seasons? (**No leap-month correction** — the lunar year is shorter than the solar year, so the calendar drifts over a ~33-year cycle.)

Chapter 15

Noon and Midnight

By the end of this chapter: I can say noon and midnight in Arabic and recognise *az-ẓuhr* as the name of the midday prayer.

Say *az-ẓuhr* and *muntaṣaf al-layl*, and name the religious sense Arabic’s noon carries.

15.1 الظهر, منتصف الليل — noon and midnight

Noon in Arabic isn’t just a clock-time word — it’s tied directly into the rhythm of daily prayer.

You’ll want to know — الظهر — noon, and a prayer

الظهر (*az-ẓuhr* or *adh-dhuhr*) = “**noon**” — from the root ظ-ه-ر (*ẓ-h-r*), “**to appear, become visible**” (the sun standing at its highest, most visible point). Be honest about what makes this word different from Spanish’s *mediodía*: الظهر is also the name of the midday Islamic prayer, *ṣalāt al-ẓuhr*. For a Muslim, “noon” and “time for the noon prayer” are the same word — this isn’t a neutral clock-time term the way “noon” or *mediodía* are in cultures where the day isn’t organized around five fixed prayer times.

You’ll want to know — الليل منتصف — a transparent “half of the night”

الليل منتصف (*muntaṣaf al-layl*) = “**midnight**,” literally “**the half of the night**.” منتصف (*muntaṣaf*) comes from the root ف-ص-ن (*n-ṣ-f*), “**half**” (the same root as نصف, *niṣf*, “a half”), and الليل (*al-layl*) is simply “**the night**.” This one is fully transparent — no erosion, no double meaning, just “the middle of the night,” structurally exactly like Latin’s *media nox*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “aḡ-ḡuhr” — noon, also the midday prayer
- “muntaṣaf al-layl” — literally “the half of the night”
- the honest point — Arabic noon carries a religious meaning that *mediodía* doesn’t

Before you move on

What does الظهر name besides the time of day? (**The midday Islamic prayer**, *ṣalāt al-ḡuhr*.) What does الليل منتصف literally mean, and what root gives it “half”? (“**The half of the night**” — *muntaṣaf*, from ن-ص-ف *n-ṣ-f*, “half.”) Is Arabic’s word for noon a neutral clock-time word the way Spanish’s *mediodía* is? (**No** — it’s bound up with the daily prayer schedule.)

Chapter 16

Telling Time

By the end of this chapter: I can ask what time it is in Arabic and answer with the hour.

Ask kam as-sāʿa? and answer with the ordinal hour, including the one-o'clock exception.

16.1 الساعة — one word for “hour,” “clock,” and “a moment”

Arabic’s word for “hour” isn’t native Arabic at all — it’s a very old borrowing, and it still carries three meanings at once.

Why it’s said this way

ساعة (*sāʿa*) = “hour” — but also “clock/watch” (as an object) and “a while, a moment” (as in “wait a *sāʿa*”). According to the historical linguist Theodor Nöldeke, Arabic ساعة was borrowed from **Aramaic** ܫܥܬܐ (*šāʿtā*) — the same Semitic root that gives Hebrew its word for hour, שָׁעָה (*šāʿā*). This borrowing happened long before Islam, deep in Arabic’s pre-Islamic contact with Aramaic-speaking communities — so unlike some of the religiously-tied vocabulary you’ve seen (like *aḏ-ḏuhr*), *sāʿa* is simply an old, everyday loanword, carrying no special religious weight.

Grammar Lens: الساعة كم — “how much is the hour?”

Arabic asks the time with الساعة كم (*kam as-sāʿa?*), literally “**how much/ how many is the hour**” — and answers with الساعة + an

ordinal number (“the second,” “the third”...):

الثانية الساعة. — “It is two o’clock.” (literally “the hour [is] the second”) الثالثة الساعة. — “It is three o’clock.” (literally “the hour [is] the third”)

Be honest about the one exception: **one o’clock breaks this pattern**. You’d expect the ordinal *al-ūlā* (“the first”), but Arabic actually says *الساعة الواحدة* (*as-sāʿa al-wāḥida*) — using **al-wāḥida**, the plain **cardinal** “one,” not the ordinal. So the rule is “ordinal numbers from two o’clock onward, except one o’clock, which uses the cardinal instead” — a genuine irregularity, not a typo. This is still a different grammatical shape than Spanish’s *la una/las dos* or French’s *une heure/deux heures*, both of which use plain cardinal numbers throughout, with no ordinal/cardinal split at all.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “sāʿa” — hour, clock, or a while, depending on context
- “kam as-sāʿa?” — what time is it?
- “as-sāʿa al-thāniya” — it is two o’clock, an ordinal number
- “as-sāʿa al-wāḥida” — it is one o’clock, the one exception, using the cardinal “one” instead

Before you move on

What language did Arabic borrow ساعة from, and what Hebrew word is its cousin? (**Aramaic** *šāʿatā*; cousin of Hebrew *šāʿā*.) What three things can ساعة mean? (**Hour, clock/watch, and a while/moment.**) Does Arabic use cardinal or ordinal numbers to tell the time — and is there an exception? (**Ordinal** from two o’clock onward — “the hour is the *second*” — but **one o’clock is the exception**, using the cardinal *al-wāḥida*, “one,” instead of the ordinal.)

Chapter 17

Asking Someone's Age

By the end of this chapter: I can ask how old someone is in Arabic and give my own age without using a verb.

Ask *kam ʿumruka?* and answer *ʿumrī ʿishrūna sana* – age as a noun you possess, no verb anywhere.

17.1 عمركم؟ كم — asking age with a noun, not a verb

You’ve seen Romance languages **have** their years, Germanic languages **be** their years, and Classical Latin itself use a third construction (“born” + accusative of duration). Arabic does something structurally different again: it doesn’t use a verb for this at all.

You’ll want to know — عمر — life, lifetime, age

عمر (*ʿumr*) = “age, lifetime, life span” — from the root ع-م-ر (*ʿ-m-r*), broadly tied to the idea of **living, dwelling, flourishing** (the same root behind the personal name **ʿUmar**, and words for “building, habitation”). Age in Arabic isn’t something you *have* or *are* — it’s expressed as a possessed noun: “your *ʿumr*,” “my *ʿumr*.”

Grammar Lens: عمركم؟ كم — no verb needed

عمركم؟ كم — “How old are you?” (to a man) — literally “**how much [is] your** *ʿumr*.” (*kam ʿumruka?*) سنة عشرون عمري — “I am twenty years old.” — literally “**my** *ʿumr* [is] twenty years.” (*ʿumrī ʿishrūna sana*.)

Notice there's **no verb “to be” at all** in the present tense here — Arabic simply juxtaposes two nouns (“my age” / “twenty years”), exactly the way it forms ordinary present-tense sentences without *is/are*. So this is a genuinely **fourth shape** for the concept: not Romance's “I **have** twenty years,” not Germanic's “I **am** twenty years [old],” not Latin's “**born** twenty years [so far],” but “**my age** [is] twenty years” — age as a possessed noun-quantity, stated without any verb at all.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “*ʿumr*” — age, lifetime, life span
- “*kam ʿumruka?*” — how old are you? (to a man)
- “*ʿumrī ʿishrūna sana*” — my age is twenty years, no verb at all

Before you move on

What does *عمر* literally mean, and what root is it from? (“**Age, lifetime**” — root *ع-م-ر*, tied to living/flourishing.) Does Arabic use a verb to state age, the way Romance (“have”), Germanic (“be”), or Latin (“born” + duration) do? (**No** — it juxtaposes “my age” and the number, with no verb needed at all.) What does *عمرک؟ کم* literally ask? (“**How much [is] your ʿumr?**”)

Chapter 18

Weather

By the end of this chapter: I can say what the weather is doing in Arabic – hot, cold, or raining.

Say *aṭ-ṭaqs*, then the verbless *al-jaw ḥārr* / *al-jaw bārid*, then *innahā tumṭir*, which does take a verb.

18.1 الطقس — weather and ritual, one root

Here’s an unexpected pairing: Arabic’s word for “weather” shares its root with the word for religious “rites.”

You’ll want to know — طقس — weather, and its plural means “rites”

الطقس (*aṭ-ṭaqs*) = “**the weather**” — from root س-ق-ط (*ṣ-q-s*). Its plural, طقوس (*ṭuqūs*), means “**rites, religious ceremonies, liturgy**” — the same root covering both “atmospheric conditions” and “prescribed ritual observances.” (Casual speech often prefers الجو (*al-jaw*, “the atmosphere”) instead, keeping *aṭ-ṭaqs* for more formal or written use.)

You’ll want to know — حار الجو / بارد — hot and cold, still verbless

حار الجو. — “It’s hot.” — literally “**the atmosphere [is] hot.**” (*al-jaw ḥārr*.)
بارد الجو. — “It’s cold.” — literally “**the atmosphere [is] cold.**” (*al-jaw bārid*.)

Same pattern as *عمرك؟ كم* from the AGE lesson: **no verb “to be”** at all — just two nouns/adjectives sitting side by side.

You’ll want to know — تمطر إنها — but rain gets its OWN personal verb

تمطر إنها. — “It’s raining.” — literally “**she is raining.**” (*innahā tumṭir* — from مطر, *maṭar*, “rain,” the same root gives تمطر, *tumṭir*, “is raining.”)

Unlike *hot* and *cold*, rain isn’t a verbless adjective sentence — Arabic uses an actual **personal verb**, *tumṭir* (“is raining”), with a **feminine dummy pronoun**, إنها (*innahā*, “she/it”), standing in as the subject. So within Arabic’s own weather vocabulary, hot/cold stay verbless while rain gets a real, conjugated verb — echoing the same “rain behaves differently from other weather” pattern Latin shows in its dedicated *pluit*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “aṭ-ṭaqṣ” — weather, same root as “ṭuqūs,” rites
- “al-jaw ḥarr. al-jaw bārid.” — it’s hot/cold, no verb
- “innahā tumṭir” — it’s raining, with an actual verb

Before you move on

What does the plural of طقس mean, and what’s the connection to “weather”? (طقوس, “rites, religious ceremonies” — sharing the same root.) Do حار الجو and بارد الجو use a verb? (**No** — verbless, like *kam ‘umruka?*.) Does تمطر إنها use a verb? (**Yes** — *tumṭir*, “is raining,” with a feminine dummy pronoun.)

Chapter 19

Numbers One to Five

By the end of this chapter: I can count from one to five in Arabic.

Count wāḥid to khamṣa, then separate the Arabic number WORDS from the Indian-origin digit shapes.

19.1 خمسة أربعة، ثلاثة، اثنان، واحد — one through five

Before the numbers themselves — an honest correction to a very common mix-up: “Arabic numerals” (the digit shapes **0, 1, 2, 3...**) are **not** these words, and don’t come from Arabic at all.

You’ll want to know — خمسة، أربعة، ثلاثة، اثنان، واحد — the words

Arabic	Transliteration	Meaning
واحد	<i>wāḥid</i>	one
اثنان	<i>ithnān</i>	two
ثلاثة	<i>thalātha</i>	three
أربعة	<i>arbaʿa</i>	four
خمسة	<i>khamṣa</i>	five

These are ordinary Semitic-root Arabic words, built the same way Arabic builds any noun — nothing to do with the shapes of the digits you write.

Why it’s said this way

Here’s the correction: the **digit shapes 0, 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 7, 8, 9** that English calls “Arabic numerals” didn’t originate in Arabic at all — they were invented in **India**, appearing in Indian mathematical

texts and inscriptions centuries before reaching the Arab world. The 9th-century Persian mathematician **al-Khwārizmī** (whose name gives English **algorithm**) wrote an influential treatise on calculating with these **Hindu numerals**, which carried the system into the Islamic world and then, via Latin translations, into Europe. So “Arabic numerals” is really a transmission credit, not an origin credit — the shapes are Indian; only their route to Europe ran through Arabic mathematics. The **words** you’re learning here (*wāḥid*, *ithnān*, *thalātha*...) are a completely separate thing: genuine, native Arabic vocabulary, unrelated to that digit-shape history.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “wāḥid, ithnān, thalātha, arbaʿa, khamṣa” — one through five
- the honest correction — “Arabic numerals” (the digit SHAPES) are actually Indian in origin, not these Arabic WORDS

Before you move on

What are the Arabic words for one through five? (**wāḥid**, **ithnān**, **thalātha**, **arbaʿa**, **khamṣa**.) Where did the digit shapes 0-9 actually originate, and who’s credited with carrying them to Europe? (**India** — carried into the Islamic world and then Europe largely through **al-Khwārizmī**’s writings.) Are “Arabic numerals” the same thing as these Arabic number words? (**No** — completely separate: one is a set of written digit shapes with Indian origins, the other is native Arabic vocabulary.)

Chapter 20

Numbers Eleven to Twenty

By the end of this chapter: I can count from eleven to twenty in Arabic and build the teens as ‘X and ten’.

Build the teens as additive X-‘ashar compounds, then say ‘ishrūn, which is not built that way at all.

20.1 عشر أحـد، عشرون — plain compounds, then a genuinely different twenty

Eleven through fifteen build the same simple way every time. Then twenty breaks the pattern completely — it isn’t built the way you’d expect at all.

You’ll want to know — عشر خمسة – عشر أحـد — “X and ten”

Arabic	literally
عشر أحـد	<i>aḥada ‘ashar</i> — “one-ten” (11)
عشر اثنا	<i>ithnā ‘ashar</i> — “two-ten” (12)
عشر ثلاثة	<i>thalāthata ‘ashar</i> — “three-ten” (13)
عشر أربعة	<i>arba‘ata ‘ashar</i> — “four-ten” (14)
عشر خمسة	<i>khamṣata ‘ashar</i> — “five-ten” (15)

Every one of these is the counting-word (from the AGE and NUM-1-5 lessons) plus عشر (*‘ashar*, “**ten**”) — a straightforward additive compound, the same shape Spanish builds in *once-quince* and Latin in *ūndecim-quīndecim*.

You'll want to know — عشرون — NOT “two-ten,” a genuinely different word

Here's the honest surprise: **twenty** is **not** built from “two” + “ten” the way 11-15 were built. عشرون (*ʿishrūn*, “twenty”) is its **own**, distinct word — a special **plural-like form** built directly on the same “ten” root, ش-ع-ر (*ʿ-sh-r*), rather than a compound of *ithnān* (“two”) and *ʿashar* (“ten”). That root, *ʿashar/ʿishrūn*, is the same Semitic “ten” root behind Hebrew's עשר (*eser*, “ten”) — and, coincidentally, resembles the Indo-European “ten” root that gives English its own **-teen** suffix, though the two roots are **not** related: Arabic and English inherited “ten” from two entirely separate language families, so this is a parallel, not a shared borrowing or common ancestor.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “aḥada ʿashar, ithnā ʿashar, thalāthata ʿashar” — 11, 12, 13, “X and ten”
- “ʿishrūn” — twenty, its OWN word, not “two-ten”

Before you move on

How are 11-15 built in Arabic? (**X** + **ʿashar** — “one-ten,” “two-ten,” and so on, a plain additive compound.) Is عشرون (twenty) built the same way, as “two-ten”? (**No** — it's a distinct, standalone plural-like form built on the same “ten” root, not a compound of “two” and “ten.”) What root does **ʿashar/ʿishrūn** share with Hebrew? (ע-ש-ר, the Semitic root for “ten,” giving Hebrew's *eser*.)

Chapter 21

Dog and Cat

By the end of this chapter: I can name a dog and a cat in Arabic.

Say kalb beside Hebrew kelev, then qitt beside Latin cattus, flagging that the cat link is still debated.

21.1 كلب, قط — a solid root, and the word that closes the loop

Spanish has a genuine dog-word mystery, and German another by way of English. Arabic’s dog-word has no such mystery — and its cat-word turns out to be a long-lost cousin of nearly every European cat-word there is.

Why it’s said this way

كلب (*kalb*, “dog”) traces to **Proto-Semitic** **kalb-* — the exact same root behind **Hebrew**’s own word for dog, קָלֵב (*kelev*) (the name **Caleb** is traditionally connected to this same root, though some scholars instead derive it from *kol-lev*, “whole-hearted”). Unlike Spanish’s *perro* or the English word that replaced “hound,” *kalb* is a solid, well-attested, unmysterious Semitic root, shared across the whole Semitic family (Aramaic, Akkadian, and more).

Why it’s said this way

Here’s how this whole arc most likely ties together: قِط (*qitt*, “cat, tom-cat”) is not just a coincidence-sounding lookalike — it’s widely **compared** to the exact same ancient **Afro-Asiatic** root behind Latin’s **cat-**

tus (alongside Nubian *kadis*, mentioned back in the Spanish and Latin lessons). Be honest about the uncertainty here, though: linguists don't fully agree on the relationship. Some argue *qitt* and *cattus* both descend from a **shared** ancestor; others have proposed that *kadis* (and even *qitt* itself) could be a **later** borrowing **from** Arabic rather than an independent cousin, reversing the direction. What's not in serious dispute is that Arabic's word for "cat" sits in the same tangled word-family as Spanish's *gato*, French's *chat*, Italian's *gatto*, and German's *Katze* — one root (or a tight cluster of related roots), spreading out in every direction from wherever cats were first domesticated, even if the exact family tree is still being worked out.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “kalb” — dog, a solid Semitic root, cousin of Hebrew's *kelev*
- “qitt” — cat, most likely a distant cousin of Latin's *cattus* and every European cat-word there is

Before you move on

What root does كلب trace to, and what's its Hebrew cousin? (**Proto-Semitic** **kalb-*; cousin of Hebrew כֶּלֶב, *kelev*.) Is كلب's relationship to Latin's *cattus* fully settled? (**No** — widely compared, most likely from a shared Afro-Asiatic root, but linguists still debate the exact relationship and direction.) What does this most likely mean for Arabic's word for “cat” compared to Spanish's *gato*, French's *chat*, and German's *Katze*? (**They most likely belong to the same tangled ancient word family** — spreading in every direction from the region where cats were first domesticated.)

Chapter 22

Green and Yellow

By the end of this chapter: I can name green and yellow in Arabic and trace *aṣfar* to the same root as *ṣifr*, ‘zero’.

Say akḥḍar beside khudār, ‘vegetables’, then aṣfar beside ṣifr, and follow ṣifr into English zero and cipher.

22.1 أخضر، أصفر — “greens” you’d recognize, and a hidden zero

Arabic’s green word hides an English-style pun. Its yellow word hides something even better — the exact root behind the word “zero” itself.

Why it’s said this way

أخضر (*akḥḍar*, “**green**”) comes from the root ر-ض-خ (*kh-ḍ-r*, “**to be green**”). That same root gives خضار (*khudār*, “**vegetables**”) — echoing the exact same move English makes when it calls vegetables “**greens**.” The same root also names the mysterious Quranic figure الخضر (*al-Khidr*), “**the Green One**” — traditionally said to be called this because the ground turned green wherever he sat or prayed.

Why it’s said this way

Here’s the real surprise: أصفر (*aṣfar*, “**yellow**”) shares its root, ر-ف-ص (*ṣ-f-r*), with صفر (*ṣifr*, “**zero, empty, void**”) — the **exact** Arabic word that gave English both **zero** (via Italian *zefiro/zero*) and **cipher** (via Medieval Latin *cifra*). So the same three-letter Arabic root sits behind

“yellow” and behind the number **zero** itself. The sources don’t fully explain *why* “emptiness” and “yellow” share a root — but the shared root itself, connecting Arabic’s yellow-word straight back to the origin of “zero,” is genuine and well documented.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “akhḍar” — green, same root as “khuḍār,” vegetables
- “aṣfar” — yellow, same root as “ṣifr,” zero
- the connection — “aṣfar, ṣifr, zero, cipher” — one Arabic root, reaching all the way into English math vocabulary

Before you move on

What root does أخضر share with “vegetables,” and what English phrase does this echo? (ر-ض-خ, *kh-ḍ-r* — echoes English calling vegetables “**greens**.”) What Quranic figure shares this root, and what does his name mean? (الخضر, *al-Khiḍr* — “**the Green One**.”) What word does أصفر share its root with, and what two English words trace back to it? (صفر, *ṣifr*, “zero, empty” — the source of English **zero** and **cipher**.)

Chapter 23

You're Welcome

By the end of this chapter: I can reply to shukran with ʿafwan, and use the same word to say excuse me.

Say ʿafwan as the reply to thanks, unpack the root 'to erase' behind it, and hear the same -an ending it shares with shukran.

23.1 عفو (ʿafwan) — “you’re welcome,” from a root meaning “to erase”

Your very first Arabic lesson already used this word once, in passing, as the reply to *shukran*. Here it gets its own full treatment — starting with a root that literally means “to erase.”

The word, taken apart — its root and its family

عفو (ʿafwan), root ʿ-f-w (ع-ف-و): the root’s core sense is “**to erase, obliterate, remove**” — and “to pardon, forgive” grows directly out of that, since forgiving something is, metaphorically, **erasing** it. The same root gives العفو (al-ʿAfuww, “**the Supreme Pardon**er”), one of the **99 names of Allah** in Islamic tradition.

You’ll want to know — Be honest: ʿafwan does more than one job

ʿAfwan answers *shukran* as “**you’re welcome**” — but depending on tone and context, the exact same word also does duty as “**excuse me,**” “**pardon,**” or “**sorry.**” One root, one word, several closely related jobs — all growing from that same “erase/pardon” sense.

Grammar Lens: the same ending as shukran itself

Look closely at the spelling: عفوًا ends in the same **tanwīn fatḥh** (“-an”) you already met in شكرًا (*shukran*) — the indefinite accusative ending. Neither word is a full sentence with its own verb; both are fixed, idiomatic accusative forms functioning as a complete conversational turn on their own. The grammar you learned once, for *shukran*, already explains *‘afwan* too.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “عفوًا” — *‘afwan*, “you’re welcome”
- the root ʿ-f-w — “to erase” → “to pardon”
- the shared ending — *shukran* and *‘afwan* both end in the same **tanwīn fatḥh**, “-an”

Before you move on

What does the root ʿ-f-w literally mean, before it comes to mean “pardon”? (“**To erase, obliterate.**”) Besides “you’re welcome,” what other jobs can *‘afwan* do? (“**Excuse me,**” “**pardon,**” “**sorry**” — context-dependent.) What grammatical ending does *‘afwan* share with *shukran*? (The **tanwīn fatḥh**, “-an” — both are fixed indefinite- accusative forms, not full sentences.)

Chapter 24

See You Tomorrow

By the end of this chapter: I can part from someone in Arabic with *ilā l-ghad*, ‘until tomorrow’.

Say ilā l-ghad, point to the ilā already known from ilā l-liqāʾ, and follow gh-d-w from ‘dawn’ to ‘tomorrow’.

24.1 إلى الغد (*ilā l-ghad*) — “see you tomorrow,” the same *ilā* again

You already have the pattern: **ilā** + a future point = “see you [then].” Here it is again, with “tomorrow” filling the slot.

You’ll want to know — The two pieces, one already familiar

إلى الغد (*ilā l-ghad*) = “until tomorrow”:

- إلى (*ilā*) — “until,” the exact same word from *ilā l-liqāʾ* (“see you [later]”).
- الغد (*al-ghad*) — “tomorrow,” root **gh-d-w** (غ-د-و).
- Note ل is a sun letter, so *al-ghad* would assimilate — but غ (*ghayn*) is a **moon letter**, so here the *l* stays put: *al-ghad*, not doubled the way *al-liqāʾ* and *as-salāma* were.

Why it’s said this way

Gh-d-w’s core sense is “to go out at dawn, early morning” — and “tomorrow” grows directly out of that “early morning” sense.

This is **not** a one-off coincidence: this **exact** shift also happened in Latin, where *māne* (“morning”) became French’s *demain* and Spanish’s *mañana* (“tomorrow”). Two completely unrelated language families — Semitic and Indo-European — independently building “tomorrow” out of “morning.”

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “ilā l-ghad” — “until tomorrow”
- the reused piece — ilā, already known from ilā l-liqāʾ
- the root echo — gh-d-w, “dawn/morning” → “tomorrow,” the same shift as Latin *māne* → *mañana*/*demain*

Before you move on

What word does **ilā l-ghad** share with **ilā l-liqāʾ**? (**Ilā**, “until.”) What does the root **gh-d-w** literally mean, before it comes to mean “tomorrow”? (**“To go out at dawn, early morning.”**) Is this morning-to-tomorrow shift unique to Arabic? (**No** — Latin’s *māne* (“morning”) independently became French’s *demain* and Spanish’s *mañana*, “tomorrow,” the same way.)

Chapter 25

Day

By the end of this chapter: I can say ‘day’ in Arabic and recognise its cognate in Hebrew’s Yom Kippur.

Say yawm, run it across the Semitic family, and mark the Egyptian sun-word origin as unsettled.

25.1 يوم (yawm) — “day,” a word shared across the whole Semitic family

This word is bigger than Arabic — it’s one of the oldest, most widely shared words across the entire Semitic language family.

You’ll want to know — يوم — “day”

يوم (yawm) — “day” — root **y-w-m**. Arabic’s day-names can compound with *yawm* — الجمعة يوم (yawm al-jum^a, “day of the gathering”) is the full, formal way to say “Friday,” the exact same “day-of-X” construct-state pattern as Latin’s *diēs Lūnae* — but colloquially, the bare day-name alone (*al-jum^a*, *as-sabt*, already taught earlier) is just as common. *Yawm* itself is also the ordinary, standalone word for “a day.”

Why it’s said this way

Yawm traces to **Proto-Semitic** **yawm-* — and this isn’t just an Arabic word with foreign relatives, it’s a genuinely **Common Semitic** word, found with the same shape and meaning across the whole family: Hebrew יוֹם (*yōm* — yes, the *yom* in **Yom Kippur**, “Day of Atonement”), Akkadian **ūmum**, and Aramaic **yawmā**. Four different Semitic

languages, one shared ancient word for “day.”

Why it’s said this way

Some scholars push the trail back even further, to a proposed **Proto-Afroasiatic** root, **yam-* (“day”) — and speculatively connect it to Egyptian *imy*, meaning “**sun**” (literally “the eye”). Be honest: this deeper connection is a genuinely **proposed**, citable scholarly idea within comparative Afroasiatic linguistics — but a minority one, not accepted by most Egyptologists (standard Egyptian dictionaries gloss *imy* as a common grammatical form, “who/which is in,” not “sun,” and ordinary Egyptian for “day” is an unrelated word, *hrw*). Not settled fact the way the Semitic-family cognates are.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “yawm” — “day”
- the Semitic family — yawm, yōm (Yom Kippur), ūmum, yawmā
- the honest deeper speculation — possibly Egyptian “sun,” not settled

Before you move on

What Hebrew word, familiar from a well-known holiday name, is **yawm**’s direct cognate? (**Yōm**, as in **Yom Kippur**.) Name two other Semitic languages that share this exact word for “day.” (**Akkadian** *ūmum*, **Aramaic** *yawmā*.) Is the proposed Egyptian “sun” connection settled fact? (**No** — a genuinely proposed but speculative deeper link.)

Chapter 26

Night

By the end of this chapter: I can say ‘night’ in Arabic and point to *layl* inside the midnight phrase I already know.

*Say *layl*, find it inside *muntaṣaf al-layl*, and pair it with *yawm* as the other pan-Semitic half of the day.*

26.1 ليل (layl) — “night,” yawm’s partner across the whole Semitic family

You’ve already met *layl* once, tucked inside *muntaṣaf al-layl* (“midnight”). Now it gets the same standalone treatment *yawm* just did — and the same pan-Semitic family story.

You’ll want to know — ليل — “night”

ليل (layl) — “night” — is the word already hiding inside **muntaṣaf al-layl** (“midnight,” Chapter 15, literally “the half of the night”). Root **l-y-l**.

Why it’s said this way

Just like *yawm*, **layl** is a genuine **Common Semitic** word, not an Arabic-only term with distant relatives. It traces to **Proto-Semitic** **layl-*, cognate with Hebrew לַיְלָה (*layla/laylah* — the same word in the famous Passover question, “*mah nishtana ha-layla ha-zeh*,” “why is **this night** different”), Aramaic/Syriac *lēlyā*, and Akkadian *līliātum*. Day and night, *yawm* and *layl*, are **both** words the whole Semitic family has shared for millennia.

Why it's said this way

Be honest about one genuine scholarly debate: linguists don't fully agree on whether Proto-Semitic had this simple **triradical** **layl-* form, or a **reduplicated** **laylay-* form instead (the doubled shape possibly surviving in some daughter languages' declension patterns). This is a real, open question in comparative Semitics — not settled the way the basic Hebrew/Aramaic/Akkadian cognate set is.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “layl” — “night,” already met inside *muntaṣaf al-layl*
- the Semitic family — *layl*, *layla* (Hebrew), *lēlyā*, *līlīātum*
- *yawm* and *layl* — day and night, both pan-Semitic words

Before you move on

Where have you already met **layl** before this lesson? (**Muntaṣaf al-layl**, “midnight.”) What Hebrew word, from a famous Passover question, is *layl*'s direct cognate? (**Layla/laylah.**) Is the exact Proto-Semitic shape of this word — triradical or reduplicated — fully settled? (**No** — a genuine, open scholarly debate.)

Chapter 27

Good Night

By the end of this chapter: I can wish someone good night in Arabic and explain why the phrase actually talks about the morning.

Say tuṣbiḥ ʿalā khayr, translate it as ‘may you wake into goodness’, and trace tuṣbiḥ back to ṣabāḥ al-khayr’s own root.

27.1 خیر علی تصبح (tuṣbiḥ ʿalā khayr) — wishing the morning, not the night

Every “good night” you’ve learned in other languages wishes a peaceful **night**. Arabic’s everyday version does something completely different — it skips the night and wishes the **morning** instead.

You’ll want to know — خیر علی تصبح — “may you wake into goodness”

خیر علی تصبح (tuṣbiḥ ʿalā khayr) is the most common everyday Arabic “good night” — but it literally means “**may you wake up into goodness**.” Break it down:

- أصبح (tuṣbiḥ) — the ordinary imperfect (“you become”) of أصبح (aṣbaḥa, “**to become morning, to wake up**”) — the **exact same root**, ح-ب-ص (ṣ-b-ḥ), as ṣabāḥ in ṣabāḥ al-khayr (“good morning,” Chapter 1). No special subjunctive or jussive form is involved — a plain statement doing the work of a blessing, the same way English “you’ll sleep well” can function as a wish without any special grammar.

- على (*‘alā*) — “upon.”
- خير (*khayr*) — “goodness” — the same word already met in **masā’ al-khayr** (“good evening”).

Put together: not “sleep well,” but “**may your waking be good.**” (This particular form, *tuṣbiḥ*, addresses one **man**; a woman is *tuṣbiḥi* [تصبحي], a group is *tuṣbiḥū* [تصبحوا].)

Why it’s said this way

Here’s the genuinely different part: the everyday “good night” of English, French, German, and Spanish wishes something about the **night itself**. Arabic’s everyday version does the opposite: it’s grammatically about the **morning that follows**, built from the same “waking” root already hiding in *ṣabāḥ*. Notice what’s genuinely absent: ليل (*layl*, “night,” last lesson) doesn’t appear anywhere in this phrase at all. It reuses pieces you already have (*ṣ-b-ḥ*, *khayr*) but points them at a **different moment in time** than every other language’s farewell.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “*tuṣbiḥ ‘alā khayr*” — literally “may you wake into goodness”
- the shared root — *tuṣbiḥ* and *ṣabāḥ*, both from *ṣ-b-ḥ*
- the honest twist — this “good night” is really about the morning, not the night

Before you move on

What does *خير على تصبح* literally mean? (“**May you wake up into goodness.**”) What root does *tuṣbiḥ* share with *ṣabāḥ al-khayr*? (*ṣ-b-ḥ*, “morning/to become morning.”) Unlike English, French, and German’s “good night,” what moment in time does Arabic’s everyday version actually point to? (**The morning that follows**, not the night itself.)

Chapter 28

Going and Coming

***By the end of this chapter:** I can say the Arabic for 'he went' and 'he came', read the three-consonant root under each, and explain why Arabic dictionaries list a verb as 'he did' rather than 'to do'.*

Say the going/coming pair, name the weak letter that vanishes from $jā'a$ and point to where it comes back, and restate the root-and-pattern engine dhahaba opened.

28.1 ذَهَبَ (dhahaba) — “he went,” and the engine under every Arabic word

Every word so far has been a thing, a quality, or a fixed courtesy. Now a **verb** — and the machine that builds nearly every word in the language.

You'll want to know — The letters in this word

Three letters, one of them new.

- د ($dāl$) — a small hook resting on the line, sounding like English *d*. It is a **non-joiner**: like *alif*, it will not connect to whatever follows it.
- ذ ($dhāl$) — that same hook with **one dot above**. The dot is the entire difference. Its sound is the *th* of English **this** — voiced — never the *th* of *thin*.
- ه ($hā'$) and ب ($bā'$) are already yours.

Right to left: ذ stands alone, then هب joins into one piece. *Dha-ha-ba*.

The word, taken apart — its root and its family

ذَهَبَ (*dhahaba*) = “**he went**.” Its root is the bare consonant skeleton ذ-ه-ب. Keep those three consonants, pour a different set of vowels between them, and out comes a different word carved from the same idea:

- ذَهَبَ (*dhahaba*) — “he went.”
- ذَهَبَ (*dhahab*) — “gold.”
- مَذْهَبَ (*madhhab*) — “a **way one goes**,” and so the word for a **school of Islamic law**.

That last one is not luck. Putting *ma-* in front of a root gives the **place or the way** of its action, and English already owns two words from that same place-noun family: مَسْجِدَ (*masjid*), “place of prostration,” worn down through Spanish into **mosque**; and مَغْرِبَ (*maghrib*), “place of sunset,” kept whole as the **Maghreb**. The pattern is already in your vocabulary. Only the root is new.

Grammar Lens — Arabic has no “to go”

English dictionaries list a verb as “**to go**.” Arabic dictionaries cannot — the language has no infinitive. The form they list is ذَهَبَ, “**he went**”: third person, masculine, singular, finished. Grammarians name each vowel pattern with a dummy root, ل-ع-ف (*f-^c-l*, “to do”), so this shape is called فَعَلَ (*fa^c-ala*). Every verb in these three chapters wears it.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- right to left — ذ, then هب — “dhahaba,” he went
- the root — dh-h-b — then dhahab, “gold,” and madhhab, “a school of law”
- the citation form — Arabic lists “he went,” never “to go”

Before you move on

What single mark separates ج from ذ, and what does it do to the sound? (**One dot above** — it turns *d* into the *th* of “this.”) Name two other words built on ذ-ه-ز. (*Dhahab*, “gold,” and *madhhab*, “a school of law.”) In what form does an Arabic dictionary list a verb? (“**He went**” — *dhahaba* — because Arabic has no infinitive.)

28.2 جاء (jāʾa) — “he came,” and a root that hides one of its own letters

Dhahaba was the tidy case: three consonants, three vowels, nothing hidden. Its opposite number is where the engine gets interesting.

You’ll want to know — The letters in this word

No new letters here — this word is built entirely from shapes you already have.

- ج (*jīm*) — the hook-and-tail body with **one dot below**, sounding like the *j* of English *jam*.
- ا (*alif*) — the clean downstroke, here carrying a long *ā*.
- ء (*hamza*) — the glottal stop, the catch in “uh-oh,” sitting on the line by itself at the end.

Right to left: ج joined, then ء standing apart. *Jāʾa* — two beats, with a hard little stop at the end.

The word, taken apart — its root and its family

جاء (*jāʾa*) = “**he came**.” Its root is أ-ي-ج — and one of those three consonants is missing from the word you just read. That is the point. Arabic calls و and ي **weak** letters. Poured into the *faʿala* shape, the root would give *jayaʾa*, which no Arab mouth wants to say; the ي dissolves and its vowel stretches into the long *ā* you hear. The skeleton is still there, though, and it walks straight back out in مَجِيء (*majīʾ*), “**an arrival**” — the same *ma-* place-and-way prefix met in *madhhab*, with the ي restored in plain sight.

So the irregularity is not chaos. It is a second rule, applied everywhere a weak letter lands in the middle. Being honest about one thing: جاء is the written, formal verb. To tell someone “come here” in ordinary speech you say تَعَالِ (*ta^cāla*), which comes from a completely **different root** meaning “to be high” — originally “come up here.”

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the pair — “dhahaba, jā^ʔa” — he went, he came
- the vanished letter — root j-y-^ʔ, and the ي back in place in “majī^ʔ”
- the everyday imperative — “ta^cāla,” from another root entirely

Before you move on

Which letter of جاء’s root never appears in the word itself, and where does it come back? (ي — restored in مَجِيء, *majī^ʔ*, “an arrival.”) What are Arabic’s two **weak** letters? (و and ي.) What word does an Arabic speaker actually use for “come here,” and is it from this root? (*Ta^cāla* — **no**, a different root meaning “to be high.”)

Chapter 29

Saying and Seeing

By the end of this chapter: I can say the Arabic for ‘he said’ and ‘he saw’, read the letters qāf and alif maqṣūra, and name the doer, done-to, place and instrument words each root builds.

Say raʿā, read its dotless alif maqṣūra, follow the root out into raʿy ‘opinion’ and mirʿāh ‘mirror’, and restate the pattern family qāla laid out.

29.1 قال (qāla) — “he said,” and a letter you have been reading unnamed

One letter has turned up in Arabic words since the farewell *ilā l-liqāʿ* without ever being introduced. Its own verb is the right place to name it.

You’ll want to know — The letters in this word

One new letter, and it is a sound English does not have.

- ق (qāf) — **two dots above** a bowl-shaped body. Joined mid-word it looks much like *bāʿ*’s bowl; alone or final it drops a deep round tail below the line. Its sound is a *k* made far back at the **uvula**, at the top of the throat — heavier and darker than English *k*.
- ا (alif) and ل (lām) are yours already.

Read قال right to left: *qāf*, long *ā*, *lām*. Be honest about the sound: in most everyday spoken Arabic ق is not said that way at all — in Cairo and

Damascus it becomes a glottal stop, and across much of the Gulf a hard *g*. The uvular version is the formal one.

The word, taken apart — its root and its family

قَالَ (*qāla*) = “**he said**.” Root **ق-و-ل** — and the same disappearing act as *jāʿa*, with the other weak letter. The plain shape would give *qawala*; the **و** dissolves and the vowel stretches to **ā**. It reappears the moment the pattern changes: قَوْل (*qawl*), “**an utterance, a saying**.” Now watch one skeleton fill four different pattern-slots:

- قَائِل (*qāʿil*) — “a **speaker**,” the **doer** shape.
- مَقُول (*maqūl*) — “**spoken**,” the **done-to** shape.
- مَقَالَة (*maqāla*) — “an **article**, an essay,” the same *ma*-place-and-way prefix that gave *madhhab*.

Those first two are the very patterns met back in *shukran*, which paired *shākir* (“thankful”) with *mashkūr* (“thanked”). Learn a pattern once and it works on every root — which is why Arabic vocabulary grows in families rather than one word at a time.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “qāla” — he said — with the deep uvular *q*
- the weak letter returning — qāla, then qawl, “a saying”
- the family — qāʿil, a speaker; maqūl, spoken; maqāla, an article

Before you move on

How many dots does **ق** carry, and where is its sound made? (**Two, above** — at the **uvula**, far back in the throat.) Which letter of the root **ق-و-ل** vanishes in *qāla*, and which word brings it back? (**و** — restored in قَوْل, *qawl*, “a saying.”) What does مَقَالَة mean, and which earlier word shares its pattern? (“**An article**” — the same *ma*-shape as *madhhab*.)

29.2 رَأَى ($ra^{\circ}\bar{a}$) — “he saw,” and how seeing becomes having an opinion

A weak letter has hidden in the middle of the last two verbs.
This time it hides at the **end** — and it wears a shape of its own.

You’ll want to know — The letters in this word

One new shape, and it is a shape you can almost already read.

- ر (ra°) — the little downward curve, a tapped *r*, and a non-joiner.
- ا — *alif* carrying **hamza**, the glottal catch, riding on top.
- ي (*alif maqṣūra*, “the shortened alif”) — this is the new one, and it is simply ي ($yā^{\circ}$) **stripped of its two dots**. Same body, no dots. Despite the $yā^{\circ}$ body it sounds like a long $\bar{a}$, and it only ever turns up at the **end** of a word. The farewell *ilā l-ghad* already carried it, unnamed.

Right to left: ra° , then *alif-with-hamza*, then the dotless tail. $Ra-^{\circ}\bar{a}$.

The word, taken apart — its root and its family

رَأَى ($ra^{\circ}\bar{a}$) = “he saw.” Root ر-أ-ي. The weak ي is the **last** consonant this time, and instead of vanishing outright it surfaces as that dotless ي. Three verbs, three placements of weakness: middle in $jā^{\circ}a$ and $qāla$, final here. Each has its own regular rules.

The family this root grows is the good part:

- رَأْيٍ ($ra^{\circ}y$) — “an **opinion**.” Literally a *seeing*. English does the very same thing with “**in my view**” and “the way **I see it**” — two unrelated languages reaching for one metaphor.
- مِرْآة ($mir^{\circ}\bar{a}h$) — “a **mirror**.” This is the **instrument** shape, *mi-* plus the root: “the thing you see with.” It is a sibling of the *ma-* place shape behind *madhhab* and *maqāla*.
- رُؤْيَا ($ru^{\circ}yā$) — “a **vision**, a dream.”

Seeing, opinion, mirror, vision: four words, one skeleton, no memorising four unrelated forms.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “raʾā” — he saw — ending on a long ā spelled with a dotless yāʾ
- the metaphor — “raʾy,” an opinion, literally a seeing
- the instrument — “mirʾāh,” a mirror, the thing you see with

Before you move on

What is ى made of, and what does it sound like? (ي *yāʾ* **without its dots** — sounding like a long ā, only ever at the end of a word.) What does رَأَى mean, and what English turn of phrase makes the same move? (“**An opinion**” — literally a seeing, like “**in my view**.”) What is مِرْآة, and what pattern builds it? (**A mirror** — the *mi-* **instrument** shape, “the thing you see with.”)

Chapter 30

Knowing and Eating

By the end of this chapter: I can say the Arabic for 'he knew' and 'he ate', tell ^ʿarafa apart from ^ʿalima, and say plainly which of these verbs has an English cousin and which has none.

Say akala with no new letters left to learn, run its doer and done-to forms, place it beside Hebrew akhal, and restate the ^ʿarafa root family and its Spanish loan.

30.1 عرف (^ʿarafa) — “he knew,” and a root that crossed into Spain

Back to a plain, regular root after three weak ones — and to a word that split into two where English has only one.

You'll want to know — The letters in this word

One new letter, and it belongs to a family already half-known.

- ع (^ʿayn) — the throat-tightening sound with no English equal, met in ^ʿalaykum and ^ʿafwan.
- ر (^{rāʾ}) — the tapped *r*, a non-joiner.
- ف (^{fāʾ}) — the new one: a small loop with a tail, carrying **one dot above**, sounding like English *f*. Its partner is ق (^{qāf}) from the *qāla* lesson: mid-word the two bodies are the same shape, and only the dots separate them — **one** dot for *f*, **two** for *q*. A fourth dots-family.

Right to left: ^ʿayn, ^{rāʾ}, ^{fāʾ} — ^ʿa-ra-fa.

The word, taken apart — its root and its family

عَرَفَ (^c*arafa*) = “he knew, he recognised” — the plain *fa^cala* shape, no weak letters, root ف-ر-ع. Its family:

- مَعْرِفَة (*ma^crifa*) — “knowledge,” the *ma-* shape.
- عُرْف (^c*urf*) — “custom,” what is commonly known.
- الْعَرِيف (*al-^carīf*) — “the one who knows,” the expert or overseer. Spanish took the word in during the centuries of Arab rule and keeps it as **alarife**, “master builder.” The palace gardens above Granada, the **Generalife**, are usually read as جَنَّة الْعَرِيف (*jannat al-^carīf*), “the garden of the ^carīf” — though scholars disagree about that second element, so treat it as the leading reading, not a settled one.

Arabic splits “know” in two. عَرَفَ is knowing a *person* or a *place* — recognising. Knowing a *fact* is a different verb, عَلِمَ (^c*alima*). Spanish cuts the same way with *conocer* and *saber*, French with *connaître* and *savoir*; English collapses both into one word. That second root gives عَالِم (^c*ālim*), “a scholar,” whose plural عُلَمَاء (^c*ulamā²*) English borrowed as **ulema**.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the dots — ف one dot, ق two dots, one body between them
- “^carafa” — he recognised — beside “^calima,” he knew a fact
- the loan — al-^carīf, Spanish *alarife*, the Generalife in Granada

Before you move on

What tells ف and ق apart? (**The dots** — one above for *f*, two for *q*.) Which of Arabic’s two “know” verbs is ^c*arafa*, and what languages make the same split? (**Recognising a person or place**, against ^c*alima* for a fact — as **Spanish** *conocer/saber* and **French** *connaître/savoir* do.) What Spanish word and what Granada palace carry **al-^carīf**? (**Alarife**, “master builder,” and the **Generalife**.)

30.2 أَكَلَ (akala) — “he ate,” and an honest word about cousins

The sixth and last verb of the set — and the one that needs no new letters at all, which is what a course built on words rather than alphabets eventually earns you.

You’ll want to know — The letters in this word

Nothing new. Every shape here has been taught already.

- ا — *alif* with **hamza** riding on top, the glottal catch, opening the word with a clean *a*.
- ك (kāf) — the angular *k*.
- ل (lām) — the tall hook.

Right to left: *a-ka-la*. Six chapters ago this word would have needed a lesson of its own just to be sounded out; now it reads itself.

The word, taken apart — its root and its family

أَكَلَ (akala) = “**he ate**.” Root ا-ك-ل, and the plain *fa^cala* shape once more. Its family runs through the patterns already collected:

- أَكَلَ (akl) — “**eating**,” and so “**food**.”
- مَأْكُولَات (ma^ʔkūlāt) — “**foodstuffs**,” the **done-to** shape from *maqūl*, made plural: the things that get eaten.
- آكِل (ākil) — “an **eater**,” the **doer** shape, where the root’s own *alif* and the pattern’s *alif* fuse into the long ī.

Now the honest part, because a false cousin is worse than none: **there is no English relative of this word**. Arabic and English are not related languages, and almost none of these six verbs has an English descendant — what English took from Arabic were nouns for goods and sciences, not everyday verbs. What *akala* does have is a **Semitic** twin: Hebrew אָכַל (akhal), “he ate,” the same three consonants in the same order, with the Hebrew noun *okhel*, “food,” standing beside Arabic *akl* — the same family resemblance heard in *salām* and *shalom*, and in *yad* and *yad*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “akala” — he ate — then “akl,” food
- the two patterns — “ākil,” an eater; “maʾkūlāt,” foodstuffs
- the honest cousin — no English relative, but Hebrew “akhal”
- all six — dhahaba, jāʾa, qāla, raʾā, ʿarafa, akala

Before you move on

What two pattern-shapes give آكِل and مَأْكُولَات, and what do they mean? (**Doer** and **done-to** — “an eater” and “foodstuffs.”) Does *akala* have an English cousin? (**No** — Arabic and English are unrelated; claiming one would be inventing it.) What is its Semitic twin? (**Hebrew** אָכַל, *akhal*, “he ate.”)

Chapter 31

Understanding, Reading, Writing

By the end of this chapter: I can say the Arabic for ‘he understood’, ‘he read’, ‘he asked’ and ‘he wrote’, and build a whole family of nouns off each root using the doer, done-to and ma- place shapes I already know.

Run ب-ت-ك through every pattern the track has taught — kitāb, kātib, maktūb, maktab, maktaba — naming the earlier word that wears each shape (qāʾil and qāriʾ for the doer, maqūl and mafhūm and maqrūʾ for the done-to, madhhab and masʾala for the ma- place), then place the root beside Hebrew katav and English ketubah.

31.1 فهم (fahima) — “he understood,” and the vowel that makes a state

Six verbs so far, every one of them a deed. This one is not: it happens inside a person — and Arabic marks that in the vowels.

The letters in this word

Nothing new in فهم itself: ف ($fāʾ$, one dot), ه ($hāʾ$) and م ($mīm$), with $fāʾ$ ’s two-dotted partner ق the pair sorted out in *ʿarafa*. That is twice running — أكل needed no new letters either.

One letter does need naming, because every word-family ahead reaches for it: و ($wāw$). You have read it unnamed inside قَوْل ($qawl$), “a saying.” It is a **non-joiner**, a small loop with a tail under the line, and it holds two jobs — the consonant w , and the long vowel $ū$.

The word, taken apart — its root and its family

فَهِمَ (*fahima*) = “**he understood.**” Root ف-ه-م.

Listen to the middle vowel. *Dhahaba*, *qāla*, *‘arafa* and *akala* all ran *a-a-a*, the فَعَلَ (*fa‘ala*) shape. *Fahima* runs *a-i-a*: فَعِلَ (*fa‘ila*), which Arabic keeps for **states** rather than deeds. Understanding is not performed; it arrives.

- فَهْمَ (*fahm*) — “**understanding,**” the bare thing.
- مَفْهُومَ (*mafhum*) — “**understood,**” the **done-to** shape of *maskūr* and *maqūl*, its long *ū* riding that و. As a noun it is “**a concept**”: a thing that has been understood.

And the flat statement *akala* insisted on holds here too: ف-ه-م **has no English relative.** *Fathom* is Germanic; the resemblance is noise. No Hebrew twin worth the claim, either.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- two words needing no new letters — *akala*, then *fahima*
- the two shapes — *akala*, *a-a-a*; *fahima*, *a-i-a*
- “*fahima*,” he understood — then *fahm*, understanding; *mafhum*, a concept
- the dots once more — ف one, ق two, one body between them
- three roots, three ideas — *ma‘rifa*, knowledge; *fahm*, understanding; *akl*, food
- the honest line — no English cousin here, as with *akala*

Before you move on

Which vowel of *fahima* differs from *akala*, and what does it mark? (The middle *i* — فَعِلَ, a state rather than a deed.) What is مَفْهُومَ? (“**Understood,**” and so “**a concept**” — the done-to shape of *maqūl* and *maskūr*.) Does *fahima* have an English cousin? (No — *fathom* is Germanic.) Which letter was named here, and where

had you read it? (و, *wāw* — inside *qawl*.)

31.2 قرأ (*qaraʾa*) — “he recited,” and the word English spells Quran

One root in this chapter did give English a word — exactly one, and it is not the word for reading.

The letters in this word

ق (*qāf*, two dots) and ر (*rāʾ*) are yours. The third is ا, *hamza* on an *alif* seat, closing the word.

Hamza is the homeless consonant. It has a sound of its own — the catch in “uh-oh” — but usually no letter, so it borrows a **seat**, and which seat depends on the vowels around it:

- ا — hamza on l, as in قَرَأَ and in أَنْتَ.
- ؤ — hamza on و, the letter named last lesson.
- ئ — hamza on ي, which gives up its dots to carry it.
- ء — and where no seat suits, hamza alone on the line, closing جاء.

Four spellings, one consonant. The seat is bookkeeping; the hamza is the sound.

The word, taken apart — its root and its family

قَرَأَ (*qaraʾa*) = “**he read**” — nearer the root’s heart, “**he recited aloud**.” Reading here is done with the voice. Root أ-ر-ق, plain *faʿala* shape.

- قَارِئ (*qārīʾ*) — “a **reader**,” the **doer** shape of *qāʾil*, hamza on its dotless *yāʾ* seat.
- مَقْرُوء (*maqrūʾ*) — “**read**,” the **done-to** shape of *mafḥūm*, long *ū* on the و, hamza left seatless at the end.
- قُرْآن (*qurʾān*) — “**the recitation**,” the thing recited. English writes it **Quran**, or **Koran**. Its long *ā* is the alif-and-hamza fusion already met in أَكِل (*ākil*), “an eater.”

That single loan is the shape of the whole story. Arabic gave English *algebra*, *alcohol*, *coffee*, *sugar* and *admiral* — goods and sciences, nouns nearly every one. Out of قرأ travelled not “to read” but the name of a book. The nearer relative is Hebrew קָרָא (*qara*), “he read.”

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- hamza’s seats — ʾ on alif, ʾ on wāw, ʾ on dotless yāʾ, ʾ on nothing
- “qaraʾa,” he recited — then qārīʾ, a reader
- the done-to pair — mafhūm, a concept; maqrūʾ, read — both on wāw
- the borrowed word — qurʾān, “the recitation,” English Quran
- the fused alif — ākil, an eater; qurʾān

Before you move on

Which three seats can hamza take, and what happens to the *yāʾ* when it serves? (ا, و and ي — the *yāʾ* **drops its dots**: ى.) Which English word descends from قرأ, and what does it mean in Arabic? (**Quran** — “**the recitation**.”) Which letter carries the long *ū* of مَقْرُوء? (و.) Which earlier word shares the fused ʾ? (أَكَلَ, *ākil*, “an eater.”)

31.3 سأل (saʾala) — “he asked,” and the Arabic word for answerable

Hamza sat at the end of the last word. Here it sits in the middle — and as the vowels shift around it, it changes seats without changing sound at all.

The letters in this word

Nothing new: س (*sān*), ʾ (hamza on its *alif* seat) and ل (*lām*). Right to left, *sa-ʾa-la*.

What is worth doing is watching that seat move while the root holds still:

- سَأَلَ (*sa^ʿala*) — the *a* keeps hamza on ل.
- سُؤَالَ (*su^ʿāl*) — the *u* pulls it onto و.
- سَائِل (*sā^ʿil*) — the *i* pulls it onto dotless ي.

One consonant, one root, three spellings — exactly the rule laid out with *gara^ʿa*, now doing its work inside a single family.

The word, taken apart — its root and its family

سَأَلَ (*sa^ʿala*) = “**he asked.**” Root س-أ-ل, the plain *fa^ʿala* shape.

- سُؤَالَ (*su^ʿāl*) — “**a question.**”
- سَائِل (*sā^ʿil*) — “**an asker,**” the doer shape that also gave *qāri^ʿ*, “a reader.”
- مَسْأَلَة (*mas^ʿala*) — the **ma-** shape: “**a matter, a problem**” — a thing asked about.
- مَسْئُول (*mas^ʿūl*) — the **done-to** shape, literally “**asked-of,**” and so “**responsible**”; as a noun, “**an official.**” Arabic builds accountability out of being the one who gets questioned, which is a fair account of what accountability is.

The Hebrew twin is exact: שָׁאַל (*sha^ʿal*), “he asked” — Arabic *s* against Hebrew *sh*, the same swap heard between *salām* and *shalom*. Its passive participle is the name שָׂאֵל (*Sha^ʿul*), English **Saul**: “asked for.” From the Arabic root, English took nothing.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the seat moving — *sa^ʿala* on alif, *su^ʿāl* on wāw, *sā^ʿil* on dotless yā^ʿ
- “*sa^ʿala*” — he asked — then *su^ʿāl*, a question
- the two doers — *qāri^ʿ*, a reader; *sā^ʿil*, an asker
- *mas^ʿala*, a matter — *mas^ʿūl*, asked-of, and so responsible
- the twins — Arabic *sa^ʿala*, Hebrew *sha^ʿal*, and the name Saul

Before you move on

Which three seats does hamza take across *saʿala*, *suʿāl* and *sāʿil*? (**Alif, wāw, dotless yāʿ** — one consonant, three spellings.) What does مَسْئُول mean literally, and what does it mean in use? (“**Asked-of**” — and so **responsible**, or an official.) Which two words here wear the doer shape? (*Sāʿil*, an asker, and *qāriʿ*, a reader.) What does the name **Saul** mean? (“**Asked for**” — from Hebrew *shaʿal*, twin of سَأَلَ.)

31.4 كَتَبَ (kataba) — “he wrote,” and the root that furnishes a library

The chapter closes on the root every Arabic grammar reaches for first. Three letters — and you already own every pattern they need.

The letters in this word

ك (*kāf*), ت (*tāʿ*, two dots) and ب (*bāʿ*, one dot below) were taught long ago. New is how they sit together: **all three join**, so كَتَبَ is one unbroken run of pen — unlike ذَهَبَ, where *dhāl* refuses to connect, or أَكَلَ, where the *alif* stands off alone.

One old mark earns its keep too: put ة (*tāʿ marbūʿa*) on مَكْتَبَ (*maktab*) and you get مَكْتَبَةٌ (*maktaba*). One letter, and an office becomes a library.

The word, taken apart — its root and its family

كَتَبَ (*kataba*) = “**he wrote**.” Root ك-ت-ب, plain *faʿala* shape. Now pour it through the patterns this track has handed you:

- كِتَابَ (*kitāb*) — “a **book**.” A written thing.
- كَاتِبَ (*kātib*) — “a **writer**,” the **doer** shape of *qāʿil* and *qāriʿ*.
- مَكْتُوبَ (*maktūb*) — “**written**,” the **done-to** shape of *maqūl* and *mafḥūm* — and in speech, what has been written for you: **fate**.
- مَكْتَبَ (*maktab*) — the **ma-** place shape of *madhhab* and *masjid*: the place of writing, a **desk**, an **office**.

- مَكْتَبَة (*maktaba*) — that place plus ة: a **library**.

Five words off one root, not one of them learned separately. That is the whole return on the root system, collected in one lesson.

No English word descends from ب-ت-ك. English does hold one from the same **Semitic** root, by way of Hebrew: a **ketubah**, the written Jewish marriage contract — כְּתוּבָה (*ketubbah*), “a written thing,” from כָּתַב (*katav*), “he wrote.” That is *maktūb*’s own pattern in the other language.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- three joined letters — kāf, tāʾ, bāʾ — “kataba,” he wrote
- the doers — qāʾil, qāriʾ, kātib
- the done-to run — maqūl, mafhūm, maqrūʾ, maktūb
- the ma- place shape — madhhab, masʾala, maktab
- the letter that moves — maktab, an office; maktaba, a library
- the Semitic twin — Hebrew katav, English ketubah

Before you move on

Name five words built here from ب-ت-ك. (*Kitāb*, *kātib*, *maktūb*, *maktab*, *maktaba*.) Which pattern gives “office,” and which two earlier words wear it? (The **ma- place shape** — *madhhab* and *masʾala*.) Which two earlier words share *kātib*’s doer shape? (*Qāʾil* and *qāriʾ*.) What single letter turns an office into a library? (ة.) Which English word comes from this root? (**None** — but **ketubah** comes from its Hebrew twin *katav*.)

Chapter 32

Taking, Thinking, Helping, Loving

By the end of this chapter: I can say the Arabic for 'he took', 'he thought', 'he helped' and 'he loved', and tell a plain verb from a rebuilt one — doubled, stretched or prefixed — by what the shape does to the root's meaning.

Say the chapter's four verbs against the four shapes they wear — ^ʾakhadha plain, fakkara doubled, sāʿada stretched, ^ʾaḥabba prefixed — then run the done-to shape across maktūb, ma^ʾkhūdh and maḥbūb and restate the ma- engine dhahaba opened.

32.1 أخذ (^ʾakhadha) — “he took,” and the last of the plain verbs

The last chapter changed the **vowels** inside a root. This one changes the **shape** of the verb itself — a doubled letter, a stretched vowel, a prefix. The verb here is the plain one, kept to measure the other three against.

The letters in this word

No new letters, and three worth re-reading:

- أ — hamza on its *alif* seat, opening the word as it opens أكل.
- خ (*khāʾ*) — the hook family's **one dot above**, the *ch* of Scottish “loch.”
- ذ (*dhāl*) — *dāl* with **one dot above**, the *th* of “this,” the letter that opened ذهب.

Right to left: *ʾa-kha-dha*. Note what the page does with it. **كتب** ran as one unbroken piece; **أخذ** cannot, because *alif* is a non-joiner. It breaks into **أ** and **خذ** — the two-piece shape of **ذهب**.

The word, taken apart — its root and its family

أَخَذَ (*ʾakhadha*) = “**he took**.” Root **أ-خ-ذ**, the plain **فَعَلَ** shape — the last verb in this book to wear it unaltered.

- **أَخَذَ** (*akhadh*) — “**taking**.”
- **آخَذَ** (*ākhidh*) — “one **taking**,” the **doer** shape of *kātib*, where the root’s own *alif* and the pattern’s fuse into long **ā** — the fusion seen in **أَكَلَ** (*ākil*), “an eater.”
- **مَأْخُودٌ** (*maʾkhūdh*) — “**taken**,” the **done-to** shape of *maktūb*.

Its Hebrew twin is **אָחַז** (*ʾahaz*), “he seized.” Two regular swaps carry you across: Arabic **خ** answers Hebrew **ח**, and Arabic **ذ** answers Hebrew **ז**. Those are standing correspondences between the languages, not guesses about this pair. English took nothing from either.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the letters — hamza on alif, khāʾ, dhāl — “*ʾakhadha*,” he took
- the same opening — **أَكَلَ**, then **أَخَذَ**, hamza on its alif seat
- which words break — *kataba* into one piece, *ʾakhadha* and *dhahaba* into two
- the dot that makes dhāl — dāl, then dhāl, the th of “this”
- the fused alif — *ākil*, an eater; *ākhidh*, one taking
- the done-to pair — *maktūb*, written; *maʾkhūdh*, taken

Before you move on

Which letter keeps **أخذ** from running as one piece, and which Chapter 31 verb did run as one? (**The *alif***, a non-joiner — against **كتب**.)

What turns ځ into ځ? (**One dot above** — *d* becomes the *th* of “this.”) Which two words fuse their alifs into Ī? (*Ākil* and *ākhidh.*) Which Hebrew consonants answer Arabic ځ and ځ? (פ and ځ — in פִּזָּז, *ʔahaz.*)

32.2 فَكَّرَ (fakkara) — “he thought,” and a root rebuilt by doubling

Every verb so far has been a bare root with vowels poured between its letters. Arabic can also **rebuild** a root, and the first way it does so is by doubling one letter.

The letters in this word

ف, ك, and ځ are all yours, and all three join, so فَكَّرَ runs as one piece.

The new thing is not a letter but a mark: َ (*shadda*), the little *w* riding the ځ of فَكَّرَ. It says “**sound this consonant twice**” — *fak-ka-ra*, not *fa-ka-ra*. You met it among the ḥarakāt and on the tail of *shukran*; here it is load-bearing, because that doubling is the whole difference between one verb and another.

Everyday Arabic prints no *shadda*, as it prints no short vowels; the reader supplies it.

The word, taken apart — its root and its family

فَكَرَ (*fakkara*) = “**he thought**, he pondered.” Root ف-ك-ځ.

Doubling a root’s middle consonant is no irregularity. It is a pattern with a name and a job: فَعَّلَ (*fa^{cc}ala*), which grammarians number **Form II**, and it generally means doing the root **hard, repeatedly**, or **to something else**. *Fakkara* is thinking worked at, while the bare root holds the raw material:

- فَكَّرَ (*fikr*) — “**thought**,” thinking as such.
- فِكْرَةٌ (*fikra*) — “**an idea**,” one thought, closed by the same ځ that made a library out of an office.
- تَفَكُّيرٌ (*tafkīr*) — “**thinking**,” the activity, on Form II’s own noun shape.

- مُفَكِّر (mufakkir) — “a thinker.” Form II builds its doer with a مُ (mu-) prefix, not the long ā of kātib. A rebuilt verb gets a rebuilt doer.

No English cousin here, and no Hebrew twin worth the claim.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the doubling — fa-ka-ra, then fak-ka-ra, shadda on the kāf
- “fakkara,” he thought — then fikr, thought; fikra, an idea
- plain beside rebuilt — ʾakhadha, then fakkara
- the two doers — kātib, a writer; mufakkir, a thinker
- the done-to shape holding steady — maktūb, maʾkhūdh

Before you move on

What does the **shadda** instruct, and which letter carries it in فَكَّرَ? (**Double the consonant** — it rides the ك.) What is Form II, and what does it do to a root? (فَعَّلَ, middle letter **doubled** — the root done hard, repeatedly, or to something else.) How does Form II build its doer, against *kataba* and ʾakhadha? (مُفَكِّر with **mu-**, against كَاتِب and أَخَذَ with a long ā.)

32.3 ساعد (sāʿada) — “he helped,” from a root meaning good fortune

The second way Arabic rebuilds a root is gentler than doubling: it stretches a vowel. What comes out is a verb pointed at somebody else.

The letters in this word

Nothing new: س (sān), ا (alif, here carrying long ā), ع (ʿayn) and د (dāl).

Two things are worth noticing. ساعد breaks in two — سا, then عد — because *alif* will not join forwards, the split that broke أخذ and ذهب while كتب ran whole. And ع sits **inside** a word here, joined on both sides, where in عرف it opened one: the *‘ayn* changes shape by position more than almost any letter, while its throat-tightening sound never changes.

The word, taken apart — its root and its family

سَاعَدَ (*sā^cada*) = “**he helped**.” Root د-ع-س — which on its own does not mean helping at all. It means **good fortune**:

- سَعِيد (*sa^cīd*) — “**happy**, fortunate,” also the name **Saeed**.
- سَعَادَة (*sa^cāda*) — “**happiness**.”

Stretch the vowel after the first root letter — فَاعَلَ (*fā^cala*), **Form III** — and the verb turns outward: doing the root **with** or **toward** another person. *Sā^cada* is bringing your good fortune to bear on somebody. That is Arabic’s account of helping.

- مُسَاعَدَة (*musā^cada*) — “**help**, assistance.”
- مُسَاعِد (*musā^cid*) — “**an assistant**,” on the same مُ doer prefix that gave *mufakkir*.

English carries one name from this root: the ruling family آل سُعود (*Āl Sa^cūd*) is what is said in **Saudi** Arabia — a family name, not a borrowed verb. Hebrew’s טַוֵּן (*sa^cad*), “to sustain,” is the twin; a מִיטָא (*mis^cada*) is a restaurant.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the pieces — سا, then عد — “sā^cada,” he helped
- which break — ʔakhadha and sā^cada in two, kataba in one
- the *‘ayn* opening *‘arafa*, then joined inside sā^cada
- the root before the help — sa^cīd, happy; sa^cāda, happiness
- doubled against stretched — fakkara’s shadda, sā^cada’s long ā

- the two mu- doers — mufakkir, a thinker; musāʿid, an assistant

Before you move on

What does Form III do to a root, and to its meaning? (**Stretches the vowel after the first letter** — فاعَلَ — and aims the action **at somebody else**.) What does د-ع-س mean before it means helping? (**Good fortune** — saʿīd, “happy.”) Which mark makes fakkara Form II, and does sāʿada carry one? (**The shadda** on the ك — and **no**.) Which English place-name carries this root? (**Saudi** Arabia, from آل سُعود.)

32.4 أَحَبَّ (ʾaḥabba) — “he loved,” and the four shapes together

The last verb of the chapter, and the last of its four shapes: plain, doubled, stretched — and now prefixed.

The letters in this word

Three letter-shapes for four consonants. ا (hamza on its *alif* seat), ح (*hāʾ*, the hook family’s undotted member, a hard breath from deep in the throat) and ب (*bāʾ*) — with the **shadda** on that final ب doubling it: أَحَبَّ is ʾa-ḥab-ba.

The mark is the one that rode the ك of فَكَّرَ, doing a different job: there it built a new verb, here it only spells a root whose last two letters are the same.

On the page the word breaks after the *alif* — أَ, then حَبَّ — the two-piece split of ساعد and أخذ once again.

The word, taken apart — its root and its family

أَحَبَّ (ʾaḥabba) = “he loved,” and more mildly “he liked.” Root ح-ب-ح. The ا on the front is **Form IV**, أَفْعَلَ (ʾafʿala): the prefix that makes a root **bring about** its own idea. Love, on this account, is something a person causes.

- حُبَّ (*ḥubb*) — “love.”
- حَبِيب (*ḥabīb*) — “beloved,” feminine حَبِيبَة (*ḥabība*); add the “my”

ending of اسمي (*ismī*) and it is حَبِيبِي (*ḥabībī*), “my beloved.”

- مَحْبُوب (*maḥbūb*) — “**beloved, well-liked**,” the **done-to** shape of *maktūb* and *maʾkhūdh*.

Hebrew’s ordinary verb for loving, אָהַב (*ahav*), is **not** a relative. The real twin is חַיִּיב (*ḥaviv*), “dear,” which is *ḥabīb* exactly. No English word descends from ح-ב-ב: *ḥabībī* travels through music, not dictionaries.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the chapter’s four — ʾakhadha, fakkara, sāʿada, ʾaḥabba
- the four shapes — plain, doubled, stretched, ʾa- prefix
- “ʾaḥabba,” he loved — then ḥubb, love; ḥabīb, beloved
- the pieces — ا alone, then حَبَّ, as ساعد split into سا and عد
- the done-to run — maktūb, maʾkhūdh, maḥbūb
- the ma- place shape from the first verb lesson — madhhab, maktab
- the rebuilt doers — mufakkir; musāʿid

Before you move on

Name this chapter’s four verbs and the shape each wears. (ʾ**Ak**hadha plain, **fak**kara doubled, **sāʿ**ada stretched, ʾ**aḥ**abba prefixed — Forms I to IV.) What does Form IV’s ا do? (**Makes the root bring about its own idea.**) Why does أَحَبَّ carry a shadda, and is it *fakkara*’s reason? (**Because the root’s last two letters are both ب** — **not** a Form II doubling.) Which Hebrew word is *ḥabīb*, and which root first showed you the *ma*- shapes? (חַיִּיב — while *ahav* is no relation — and ב-ה-ז, in *madhhab*.)

Chapter 33

Asking for a Drink

By the end of this chapter: I can name tea, milk, sugar and coffee in Arabic and ask for any of them politely, and I can tell at sight whether an Arabic noun is feminine.

Say the chapter's drinks and name which of them Arabic built and which it borrowed — ḥalīb from ḥalaba, 'he milked', against shāy and sukkar, which arrived with no root at all — then read the š off qahwa as a gender marker, place it beside maktaba and as-salāma, and order each drink with min faḍlik, answering ʿafwan.

33.1 شاي (shāy) — “tea,” and a word with no root

Every Arabic word you have taken apart so far had a root under it. This one does not — and that absence is the lesson.

The letters in this word

Nothing new. ش (shīn) has been on the page since شكرًا (shukran): the sīn skeleton with three dots above it. Then ا (alif), the non-joiner, and ي (yāʾ).

So شاي breaks where alif forces it to break: شا, then ي. That is the same two-piece split you met in أحب — ا standing alone, then حب.

The word, taken apart — its root and its family

شاي (shāy) = “tea.”

Now the honest part. Take كتب (kataba): its root pours into كتاب (kitāb, a book), كاتب (kātib, a writer), مكتب (maktab, an office) and مكتبة (maktaba, a library). Try that with shāy and nothing comes out. There is no shape it fills, no doer, no place, no done-to.

That is because **shāy** is **borrowed**, and a borrowed word arrives without a root. Arabic took it through Persian چای (*chāy*), which took it from the **northern Chinese** *chá*.

Your own language took the same Chinese word by the other road. Traders on the southern coast of China said it *tê*, Dutch ships carried that form to Europe, and it became English **tea**, French **thé**, German **Tee**. Overland through Persia it stayed *chá*: Russian **чай**, Turkish **çay**, Arabic **shāy**.

So *shāy* and *tea* are not merely similar. They are the two ends of one word, separated by which way it left China.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- shīn, alif, yāʾ — “shāy,” tea
- where it breaks — shā, then yāʾ, as أَحَبَّ broke after the alif
- what a root gives — kitāb, kātib, maktab, maktaba
- what shāy gives — nothing, because it was borrowed
- the overland road — Chinese *chá*, Persian *chāy*, Arabic *shāy*
- the sea road — Hokkien *tê*, Dutch, English *tea*

Before you move on

Why can you not build a word family from شاي? (**It has no Arabic root** — it was borrowed, and borrowed words arrive without one.) Name what ب-ت-ك builds, for contrast. (*Kitāb*, *kātib*, *maktab*, *maktaba*.) Which language handed *shāy* to Arabic, and which language did that one take it from? (**Persian**, from **Chinese**.) Is English *tea* a relative? (**Yes** — the same Chinese word, carried by sea rather than overland.)

33.2 حليب (ḥalīb) — “milk,” and the verb underneath it

Yesterday’s word had no root to stand on. This one has a root so plain you can hear the verb inside the noun.

The letters in this word

Nothing new again. ح (*ḥāʾ*) is the undotted member of the hook-and-tail family — the body it shares with خ (*khāʾ*, one dot above) and ج (*jīm*, one dot below). It is the hard breath from deep in the throat that opens أَحَبَّ (*ʾaḥabba*).

Then ل (*lām*), ي (*yāʾ*) carrying the long ī, and ب (*bāʾ*).

All four join, so حليب runs as one unbroken stroke — the opposite of شاي, which had to stop at its *alif*.

The word, taken apart — its root and its family

حَلَبَ (*ḥalaba*) = “milk.” Root ح-ل-ب, and its verb is حَلَبَ (*ḥalaba*), “he milked.” So the noun is simply the milked thing.

You have met this exact transparency before. خُبْز (*khubz*, bread) sits on خ-ب-ز, “to bake”: the baked thing. Arabic does this constantly — name the action, and the everyday noun falls out of it.

The pattern *ḥalīb* wears, فَعِيل (*faʿīl*), is one to keep. It takes a root and hands back a quality or a result you can hold.

Hebrew has the word unchanged: חָלָב (*ḥalav*), “milk,” the same root doing the same job — the family resemblance already heard in *salām* and *shalom*.

One caution, because a good story is not the same as a true one. The Syrian city حَلَب (*Ḥalab*, English **Aleppo**) is often explained as a milk name. It is not: *Ḥalab* appears in Bronze Age records centuries before Arabic was written, so the milk account is a later invention hung on a name that already existed. No English word descends from ح-ل-ب at all.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the hook family — ḥāʾ no dot, khāʾ one above, jīm one below
- ḥāʾ, lām, yāʾ, bāʾ — “ḥalīb,” milk
- the verb under it — “ḥalaba,” he milked
- the same move in bread — khubz, from kh-b-z, to bake
- the pattern — faʿīl, as in ḥalīb

- the borrowed one against the built one — *shāy*, then *ḥalīb*
- the Hebrew twin — *ḥalav*

Before you move on

What does the root ح-ل-ب mean as a verb? (**To milk** — so *ḥalīb* is the milked thing.) Which earlier word works the same way? (***Khubz*** — bread, from *kh-b-z*, to bake.) Which of the chapter’s words so far has no root at all? (***Shāy*** — it was borrowed.) Is Aleppo named for milk? (**No** — the name is far older than Arabic; that story is folk etymology.)

33.3 سكر (*sukkar*) — “sugar,” and an Arabic article stuck to a Spanish word

Another traveller — and this one left a piece of Arabic grammar behind in Spain.

The letters in this word

Nothing new. س (*sīn*), the low comb; ك (*kāf*), the angular *k*; and ر (*rā*), the little downward curve that **breaks** — a non-joiner, like *alif*. So سكر joins from *sīn* to *kāf*, and *rā* hangs off the end.

Written fully it is سُكَّر, and the mark over the ك is the **shadda**. You have seen it do two jobs. On فَكَّر (*fakkara*) it built a new verb out of an old root. Here it does the quieter job it did on أَحَبَّ: it spells a letter the word already owns twice over — *suk-kar*.

The word, taken apart — its root and its family

سُكَّر (*sukkar*) = “**sugar**.” Like *shāy*, and unlike *ḥalīb*, it is **borrowed**: no Arabic root, no family of shapes.

Its road west starts in **Sanskrit**, where **śarkarā** meant “grit, gravel” — sugar named for its coarse grains. **Persian** took it as *shakar*, Arabic as *sukkar*, and Arabic carried it into medieval **Latin** as *succarum*. From there: Italian **zucchero**, French **sucre**, German **Zucker**, English **sugar**.

Then **Spanish**, which shows what the others hide. Spanish for sugar is **azúcar** — and that opening *a-z-* is Arabic’s own ا (al-), the article,

welded onto the front of the noun. Spanish borrowed **al-sukkar** whole and never took it apart.

You know why the *l* vanished: س is a **sun letter**, so *al-* + *sukkar* is said **as-sukkar**, as *al-* + *salām* is said **as-salām**. Spanish kept the sound, not the spelling. English holds *algebra* and *alcohol*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- sīn, kāf, rā — and rā breaks, so nothing joins after it
- “sukkar,” sugar — the shadda doubling the kāf, suk-kar
- the shadda’s two jobs — fakkara built a verb, ʾaḥabba spelled one
- the road — Sanskrit śarkarā, Persian shakar, Arabic sukkar
- the article that stayed — as-sukkar, Spanish azúcar
- the sun letter — al- plus salām said as-salām
- borrowed, borrowed, built — shāy, sukkar, ḥalīb
- the letters before it — shīn, alif, yāʾ; then ḥāʾ, lām, yāʾ, bāʾ

Before you move on

Which letter in سكر refuses to join what follows? (**Rā.**) What is the shadda doing here, and which earlier verb used it the same way? (**Only spelling a doubled letter** — as in ʾaḥabba, not as in fakkara.) What language did *sukkar* come from before Persian? (**Sanskrit** — śarkarā, “grit.”) What is hiding at the front of Spanish *azúcar*? (**Arabic al-**, said *as-* before a sun letter.)

33.4 قهوة (qahwa) — “coffee,” the tied tāʾ, and asking for all of it

The chapter closes on a word your own language already borrowed — and on the small letter at its end that tells you the word is feminine.

The letters in this word

Nothing new. ق (*qāf*, two dots above), the *k* made far back in the throat; ه (*hāʾ*), the loop that changes shape wherever it stands; و (*wāw*), a non-joiner like *rā*; and then ۀ.

ۀ is the **tāʾ marbūṭa**, the “tied *tāʾ*” — an ه with *tāʾ*’s two dots on it. It appears only at the end of a word.

The word, taken apart — its root and its family

قهوة (*qahwa*) = “**coffee**.”

Here is what the ۀ buys you. Arabic nouns carry **gender**, and Arabic usually **shows** you which is which: a noun ending in ۀ is almost always **feminine**. That is a rule you apply on sight, not a list to memorise. You have watched it work already:

- مَكْتَب (maktab), an office, becomes مَكْتَبَة (maktaba), a library.
- سَلَام (salām), peace, becomes السَّلَامَة (as-salāma), the safety — the root م-ل-س wearing an ending and a pattern.

So *qahwa* is feminine, while *shāy*, *ḥalīb* and *sukkar* are masculine — and the ending alone told you.

The road out of Arabic is short and well lit. Ottoman **Turkish** took *qahwa* as **kahve**; Venetian traders took *kahve* as Italian **caffè**; from Italian came French **café**, German **Kaffee** and English **coffee**. The English word in your mouth is this Arabic one.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- qāf, hāʾ, wāw, tāʾ marbūṭa — “qahwa,” coffee
- the tied tāʾ — an hāʾ wearing tāʾ’s two dots, only at a word’s end
- what it marks — feminine; maktab becomes maktaba, salām becomes as-salāma
- gendered — qahwa feminine; shāy, ḥalīb, sukkar masculine
- order each — “shāy, min faḍlik”; “qahwa, min faḍlik”; “ḥalīb, min faḍlik”; “sukkar, min faḍlik”

- the answer to thanks — “*ʿafwan*,” think nothing of it
- ḥalīb joined throughout, sukkar’s rā broke, and the wāw breaks here
- built against borrowed — ḥalaba gave ḥalīb; shāy and sukkar gave nothing

Before you move on

Which of this chapter’s words is feminine, and how can you tell? (*Qahwa* — **it ends in ʾ**.) Name two earlier words with that ending. (*Maktaba* and *as-salāma*.) Ask for each drink politely. (*Shāy*, *qahwa*, *ḥalīb*, *sukkar* — each with *min faḍlik*, “from your grace.”) What do you answer when someone thanks you? (*ʿAfwan*.) Which word here was built from a verb? (*Ḥalīb*, from *ḥalaba* — the others travelled in.)

Chapter 34

Asking for Food

By the end of this chapter: I can ask for salt, meat, cheese and food in Arabic, and I can build the word for a restaurant myself out of a root and the ma- place shape.

Name ط as the emphatic partner of ت beside ص under س and ض under د, then pour م-ع-ط through the ma- place shape that already gave maktab and madhhab to generate maṭʿam, ‘a restaurant’, and ask for the chapter’s foods with min faḍlik.

34.1 ملح (milḥ) — “salt,” and the sailor hiding in it

A word for something you can hold in one hand — whose root stretches from a mineral to the open sea to a compliment.

The letters in this word

Nothing new, but one shape is worth a second look. م (*mīm*), ل (*lām*), ح (*ḥāʾ*) — all three join, so ملح is one run of pen.

The ح is the hook-and-tail letter that opened حليب (*ḥalīb*), but at the **end** of a word it grows its full tail and swings below the line: open at the start of *ḥalīb*, closed and tailed at the end of *milḥ*.

قهوة made the same point at the other end of a word: ّ exists only in final position.

The word, taken apart — its root and its family

مِلْح (*milḥ*) = “salt.” Root م-ل-ح, and this is a root that has gone travelling inside its own language:

- مَلَّاح (*mallāḥ*) — “a sailor.” The man of the salt water. It wears the doubled *lām* shape Arabic keeps for trades and habits.
- مَلِيح (*malīḥ*) — “handsome, pleasant.” Salty, said of a person. Arabic reached for the same idea English reaches for when it calls a person *the salt of the earth*.

Note *malīḥ*’s shape: فَعِيل (*faʿīl*), the same pattern that gave you حَلِيب (*ḥalīb*). A root plus that pattern hands back a quality.

Hebrew has מֶלַח (*melaḥ*), “salt,” unchanged — one more Semitic twin. English is **not** in this family: *salt* comes down from Latin *sāl* and its Germanic cousins. And unlike *sukkar*, nothing here was borrowed.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- mīm, lām, ḥāʾ — “milḥ,” salt
- ḥāʾ in two places — opening ḥalīb, closing milḥ with its tail
- the root’s reach — mallāḥ, a sailor; malīḥ, handsome
- the faʿīl pattern twice — ḥalīb, malīḥ
- the Hebrew twin — melaḥ; and no English relative, only Latin *sāl*
- the borrowed one for contrast — *sukkar*, from Sanskrit by way of Persian
- the letters just behind — sīn, kāf, rā; qāf, hāʾ, wāw, tāʾ marbūʿa

Before you move on

What else does م-ل-ح give besides salt? (*Mallāḥ*, a sailor, and *malīḥ*, handsome.) Which pattern do *malīḥ* and *ḥalīb* share? (*Faʿīl*.) Why does the ح of *milḥ* not look like the ح of *ḥalīb*? (**It is at the end of the word**, so it takes its full tailed shape.) Does English *salt* belong

to this family? (**No** — it descends from Latin *sāl*.)

34.2 لحم (laḥm) — “meat,” and the town on the seam

This word and its Hebrew twin are the same root — and they mean different foods. There is a town whose name proves it.

The letters in this word

Nothing new, and something pleasing: لحم is ملح read the other way about. The same shapes — ل (*lām*), ح (*ḥāʿ*), م (*mīm*) — in a different order, and so a different root and a different word.

That is the root system stated as plainly as it can be. The letters are not the word. The **order** is the word.

Here *ḥāʿ* sits in the **middle**, so it wears its joined-both-sides shape: neither *ḥalīb*’s open opening nor *milh*’s tailed ending.

The word, taken apart — its root and its family

لَحْم (*laḥm*) = “**meat**.” Root ل-ح-م.

Now the twin, and it is the best one in this book. Hebrew’s לֶחֶם (*leḥem*) is the same root — and it means **bread**.

Neither language changed the meaning. The old Semitic root named **the staple food**, and each people filled it with whatever theirs was: meat where herds mattered, bread where grain did.

English already owns the proof. The town is لحم بيت (*Bayt Laḥm*) in Arabic and לֶחֶם בֵּית (*Bēt Leḥem*) in Hebrew — one name, in which *bayt* and *bēt* both mean “a house of.” English calls it **Bethlehem**: house of bread on one side of the seam, house of meat on the other.

And notice what Arabic did **not** do. It had this root available for bread and did not use it. Arabic’s bread is خُبْز (*khubz*), built on ز-ب-خ, “to bake” — the baked thing, as *ḥalīb* is the milked thing.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *lām*, *ḥāʿ*, *mīm* — “*laḥm*,” meat

- the same shapes reordered — mīm, lām, ḥāʾ is “milḥ,” salt
- ḥāʾ in the middle, joined on both sides
- the twin that shifted — laḥm is meat, Hebrew leḥem is bread
- the town on the seam — Bayt Laḥm, Bēt Leḥem, Bethlehem
- Arabic’s own bread — khubz, from kh-b-z, to bake
- the salt root’s reach — mallāḥ, malīḥ
- qahwa’s letters and its feminine ending — qāf, hāʾ, wāw, tāʾ marbūʿa

Before you move on

What separates لحم from ملح? (**Only the order of the letters** — the whole root system.) What does Hebrew *leḥem* mean, and why is that no contradiction? (**Bread** — the root named the **staple food**.) Which English place name carries both? (**Bethlehem**.) What is Arabic’s own word for bread, and where from? (***Khubz***, from ز-ب-خ, “to bake.”)

34.3 جبن (jubn) — “cheese,” and where the root system stops

The root system has been paying you back for chapters. This word is where it politely declines to.

The letters in this word

Nothing new. ج (*jīm*) is the third of the hook-and-tail family: the body of ح (*ḥāʾ*) and خ (*khāʾ*), marked by one dot **below**. Then ب (*bāʾ*), one dot below, and ن (*nūn*), one dot above.

Dots are the whole difference here, as they were between the ḥāʾ of لحم and the khāʾ of خبز.

The word, taken apart — its root and its family

جُبْن (*jubn*) = “**cheese**.” In everyday speech you will more often hear جُبْنَة (*jibna*) — and that ending is the ة you now recognise on sight, doing its usual work.

Now the honest part, because you have been taught to trust roots and this is where that trust needs a limit.

جُبْن also means “**cowardice**,” and جَبَان (*jabān*) is “**a coward**.” Same letters, same order. So is a cheese a coward?

No. Arabic’s dictionaries list these as **separate entries** — words spelled alike, not one idea branching. Compare a real root: م-ل-ح carries salt into *mallāḥ*, the sailor of salt water, and into *malīḥ*, a salty compliment. You can feel the thread. Between cheese and cowardice there is none, and inventing one would be the mistake the milk story made of Aleppo.

Two words can share three letters by accident. Arabic has many roots and few letters.

English took none of this: **cheese** comes from Latin **cāseus**.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- jīm, bā[◌], nūn — “jubn,” cheese
- the hook family by dots — ḥā[◌] none, khā[◌] one above, jīm one below
- the everyday form — jibna, with the tied tā[◌]
- the accident — jubn is also cowardice, jabān a coward
- the verdict — separate words, not one root branching
- a real branching — milḥ, mallāḥ, malīḥ
- meat and salt — laḥm, milḥ, the same shapes reordered

Before you move on

What separates ج from ح and خ? (**One dot below.**) What else do the letters of *jubn* spell? (**Cowardice** — *jabān* is a coward.) Are cheese and cowardice one root? (**No** — separate words that look alike.) Name a root that really does branch. (م-ل-ح — *milḥ*, *mallāḥ*, *malīḥ*.) What does the ending on *jibna* tell you? (**Feminine**, as *qahwa* is.)

34.4 طعام (ṭaʿām) — “food,” and a restaurant you can build yourself

A new root, a new letter — and a word you will not have to be taught, because you already own the shape it comes in.

The letters in this word

One letter to name at last. ط is ṭāʾ, the **emphatic** partner of ت (tāʾ): the same *t*, said with the tongue flat, so the syllable goes dark around it.

Arabic keeps a small set of emphatic pairs, and you have met the others without being told they were a set:

- ص (ṣād) is the emphatic س (sīn) — the ص of صباح (ṣabāḥ).
- ض (ḍād) is the emphatic د (dāl) — the ض of من فضلك (min faḍlik).
- ط (ṭāʾ) is the emphatic ت (tāʾ) — this one.

Then ع (ʿayn), the throat sound already named, ا (alif) and م (mīm). Ṭāʾ joins; alif does not, so طعام runs طعا, then م.

The word, taken apart — its root and its family

طعام (ṭaʿām) = “food.” Root ط-ع-م, whose verb طَعِمَ (ṭaʿima) means “he tasted,” and whose bare noun طَعْم (ṭaʿm) is “taste, flavour.”

So Arabic has two ways to speak of eating. أَكَلَ (akala) is the plain act — he ate. ط-ع-م goes through the tongue: tasting, and so the food that gets tasted.

Now take the م **place shape** you own. It made مَكْتَب (maktab), the place of writing, from ب-ت-ك, and مَذْهَب (madhhab) from ب-ه-ز. Put ط-ع-م through it:

مَطْعَم (maṭʿam) — the place of eating. **A restaurant.**

Nobody taught you that word. The pattern did.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- ṭāʾ, ʿayn, alif, mīm — “ṭaʿām,” food
- the emphatic set — ṣād under sīn, ḍād under dāl, ṭāʾ under tāʾ

- where you had them — ṣabāḥ, min faḍlik, now ṭaʿām
- the verb and the bare noun — ṭaʿima, he tasted; ṭaʿm, taste
- two ways to eat — akala the act, ṭaʿima the tasting
- the ma- place shape — madhhab, maktab, so maṭʿam, a restaurant
- the chapter’s foods — milḥ, laḥm reversing its letters, jubn, ṭaʿām
- order them — “laḥm, min faḍlik”; “jubn, min faḍlik”
- and the odd old one — māʾ, water, whose plural miyāh keeps no pattern

Before you move on

Which plain letter is ط the emphatic partner of, and name the other pairs. (ت — with ص under س and ض under د.) What does ط-ع-م mean as a verb? (**To taste.**) Build “restaurant” from it, and name the earlier words in that shape. (**Maṭʿam** — like **maktab** and **madhhab**.) Ask for the chapter’s foods politely. (**Milḥ, laḥm, jubn, ṭaʿām** — each with **min faḍlik**, “from your grace.”) Which everyday word keeps no pattern at all? (**Māʾ** — its plural **miyāh** is irregular.)

Chapter 35

The People You Introduce

By the end of this chapter: I can name and introduce a neighbour, a son, a daughter and a friend in Arabic, and say what single letter genders a pair of them.

Take *ṣadīq* back to ق-د-ص, ‘to be truthful’, and run the family *ṣidq*, *ṣādīq*, *ṣadaqa* and *aṣḍiqāʿ*, naming the fa^cil pattern it shares with *ḥalīb* and *malīḥ* and the doer shape it shares with *qāʿil* and *kātib*, then line up the people already owned — *ab*, *umm*, *akh*, *ukht* — against *jārī*, *ibn*, *bint* and *ṣadīqī*.

35.1 جار (jār) — “neighbour,” and a root with a letter in hiding

After a chapter of things you order, a chapter of people you introduce — starting with the one who lives next door.

The letters in this word

Nothing new, and it is short: ج (*jīm*, the hook-and-tail body with one dot below), ا (*alif*) and ر (*rā*). Both ا and ر are non-joiners, so جار barely joins at all — compare طعام, which broke once before its *mīm*.

The word, taken apart — its root and its family

جار (*jār*) = “a neighbour.” Add the “my” ending of اسمي (*ismī*) and you have جاري (*jārī*), “my neighbour” — which is how the word usually arrives in a conversation.

Now listen to the root. You can hear only *j* and *r*. But an Arabic root wants three consonants, and the missing one is in hiding: the root is

ج-و-ج, and its و has collapsed into that long ʾ.

You have watched this before. قال (*qāla*), “he said,” is ل-و-ق with the same disappearing و. Arabic calls these **hollow** roots, and the hidden letter comes back when the word changes shape:

- جَاوَرَ (*jāwara*) — “he lived alongside.” There is the و, in the open.
- جِيرَان (*jīrān*) — “**neighbours**,” where it returns as a long ī.

Hebrew’s גֵּר (*ger*), a resident outsider living among a people, comes from the same Semitic root for dwelling alongside.

English **neighbour** is no relative — it is Germanic, the *nigh-dweller*. Two unrelated languages built one word out of one idea, worth noticing **because** it is not descent.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- jīm, alif, rā — “jār,” a neighbour
- with the my ending — “jārī,” my neighbour, as ismī is my name
- the hidden letter — the root is j-w-r, and the wāw is inside the alif
- the same hiding place — qāla, he said, from q-w-l
- where it comes back — jāwara; jīrān, neighbours
- the hook family by dots — ḥāʾ, khāʾ, jīm
- the restaurant you built — maṭʿam, the place of eating
- the honest non-cousin — English neighbour, the nigh-dweller

Before you move on

What is جَار’s third root letter, and where has it gone? (و — collapsed into the long *alif*, as in *qāla* from ل-و-ق.) Where does it resurface? (In *jāwara* and *jīrān*.) How do you say “my neighbour”? (*Jārī* — the ending of *ismī*.) Is English *neighbour* related? (No — Germanic, the *nigh-dweller*.)

35.2 ابن, بنت (ibn, bint) — son and daughter, one letter apart

A pair you can learn in one move, because Arabic has already shown you the move it uses.

The letters in this word

Nothing new in either. ابن is ا (alif), ب (bā², one dot below) and ن (nūn, one dot above) — two letters that share a bowl and differ only by where the dot sits.

بنت is the same ب and ن, then ت (tā², two dots above) on the end. Both words join throughout, unlike جار, which stopped twice.

The word, taken apart — its root and its family

ابن (*ibn*) = “a son.” بنت (*bint*) = “a daughter.”

What separates them is **one** ت, and nothing else.

You have met that letter doing that job. أخ (*akh*) is a brother; أخت (*ukht*) is a sister. Same word, one ت added for the feminine. Arabic does not build a separate word for the woman; it marks the word it has. (This is the bare cousin of the ّ that marks *qahwa* feminine — same letter, tied instead of open.)

On the root, tradition and comparison disagree. Arab grammarians file ابن under بن-ن-ب, “to build” — a son as what a house is built of, which is a lovely idea. Comparative scholars are less sure: Hebrew בן (*ben*) and בַּת (*bat*) show the same bare shape, more like a very old primitive word than something derived from a verb. Hold it loosely.

Hebrew *bat* is *bint* with the **n** swallowed into the **t**. And *ibn* stands in plain sight inside names English carries: **Ibn Sīnā**, the physician the Latin west called Avicenna. No English **word** descends from it.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- alif, bā², nūn — “ibn,” a son
- bā², nūn, tā² — “bint,” a daughter
- the dots that separate bā² and nūn — one below, one above

- the move you already knew — *akh*, then *ukht*
- and the parents beside them — *ab*, a father; *umm*, a mother
- the loosely held root — *b-n-y*, to build, as the grammarians have it
- the Hebrew pair — *ben*, *bat*
- the neighbour, and the emphatic $\text{ṭā}^{\text{ʕ}}$ of $\text{ṭā}^{\text{ʕām}}$ — *jārī*; $\text{ṭā}^{\text{ʕām}}$, $\text{maṭ}^{\text{ʕām}}$

Before you move on

What is the only difference between *ابن* and *بنت*? (**An added ت** — as with ***akh*** and ***ukht***.) And the parents? (***Ab*** and ***umm***.) What root do grammarians give *ibn*, and why hold it loosely? (**ي-ن-ب**, “**to build**” — but Hebrew *ben* and *bat* suggest an older bare word.) Where does *ibn* appear in a name English knows? (***Ibn Sīnā***, Avicenna.)

35.3 صديق (*ṣadīq*) — “friend,” the one who is true to you

The chapter closes on a word whose root is not about company at all. It is about telling the truth.

The letters in this word

Nothing new. *ص* (*ṣād*) is the emphatic *س*, first met in *صباح* (*ṣabāḥ*) — heavy and dark where *sīn* is light. Then *د* (*dāl*), *ي* (*yāʾ*) carrying the long *ī*, and *ق* (*qāf*). *د* is a non-joiner, so *صديق* breaks after it: *صد*, then *يق*.

The feminine is *صديقة* (*ṣadīqa*) — the *ḍ*, tied on the end, doing what it did to *qahwa*: the open *ت* of *بنت* and *أخت* in its tied form.

The word, taken apart — its root and its family

صديق (*ṣadīq*) = “a friend.” Root *ص-د-ق*, and the root means “**to be truthful, to be sincere**.”

A friend, in Arabic, is defined by honesty rather than proximity. The family agrees:

- *صدق* (*ṣidq*) — “**truth, sincerity**.”

- صَادِق (ṣādiq) — “**truthful**,” the **doer** shape worn by قَائِل (qāʾil, a sayer) and كَاتِب (kātib, a writer).
- صَدَقَة (ṣadaqa) — “**voluntary alms**.” A gift given for its own sake: a **true** gift, as against one owed.
- أَصْدِقَاء (aṣḍiqāʾ) — “**friends**.”

And now the pattern. صَدِيق is فَعِيل (faʿīl) — the shape of حَلِيب (ḥalīb), the milked thing, and مَلِيح (malīḥ), the salty one. Root plus faʿīl hands back a quality made into a person or a thing.

This is the machinery that turned سَلَام (salām) into السَّلَامَة (as-salāma): one root, several patterns, several words.

English took nothing from ق-د-ص. *Friend* is Germanic, from an old word for loving.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- ṣād, dāl, yāʾ, qāf — “ṣadīq,” a friend
- the emphatic pair — sīn light, ṣād heavy, as in ṣabāḥ
- what the root means — to be truthful; a friend is one who is true
- the family — ṣidq, ṣādiq, ṣadaqa, aṣḍiqāʾ
- the doer shape — qāʾil, kātib, ṣādiq
- the faʿīl shape — ḥalīb, malīḥ, ṣadīq
- the feminine — ṣadīqa, tied tāʾ, as as-salāma has it
- this chapter’s people — jāri with its two non-joiners, ibn, bint, ṣadīqī
- and the family you had — ab, umm, akh, ukht

Before you move on

What does ق-د-ص mean, and what does that make a friend? (**To be truthful** — the one who is true to you.) Name the family. (**Ṣidq**, **ṣādiq**, **ṣadaqa**, **aṣḍiqāʾ**.) Which earlier words wear ṣadīq’s faʿīl

pattern, and which wear *ṣādiq*'s doer shape? (**Ḥalīb** and **malīḥ**; **qā'il** and **kātib**.) Introduce the people you can now name. (**Jārī**, **ibn**, **bint**, **ṣadīqī** — beside **ab**, **umm**, **akh**, **ukht**.) What does the *ṣ* of *ṣadīqa* do? (**Marks it feminine** — as on *qahwa* and *as-salāma*.)

Chapter 36

Cups, Plates, and More Than One

By the end of this chapter: I can ask for oil, a cup, a plate and a spoon in Arabic, and I can tell a broken plural from a sound one and say which kind of noun usually takes which.

Set the mi- tool shape of mil^caqā and mir^ʔāh against the ma- place shape of maṭ^cam and maktab, then sort the plurals: akwāb, aṭbāq and malā^ciq re-poured into a new shape against qahawāt and ṣadiqāt, which only add an ending — and ask for each thing with min faḍlik.

36.1 زيت (zayt) — “oil,” and a letter you already knew

One new letter to name — and you will find you already own it, because it is an old letter wearing a dot.

The letters in this word

ز is **zāy**, the *z*. And here is all there is to it: ر (rā) with **one dot above**.

That is the abjad’s favourite trick. ب, ن and ت share one bowl and differ by dots. ح, خ and ج share one hook. Now ر and ز share one curve.

Everything *rā* does, *zāy* does: it hangs below the line and **refuses to join** what follows — the non-joiner that ended سكر.

Then ي (yā^ʔ) and ت (tā^ʔ). So زيت is ز alone, then يت joined.

The word, taken apart — its root and its family

زَيْت (zayt) = “oil” — in the first place olive oil, and by extension oil of any kind. Root ت-ي-ز, which also gives:

- زَيْتُون (*zaytūn*) — “**olives**.”
- زَيْتُونَة (*zaytūna*) — “**an olive**,” one of them, with the tied *ḍ* making the single thing out of the collective.

And now Spain. You met **azúcar** and found Arabic’s **al-** welded onto its front. The same thing happened here, twice over:

- الزَّيْت (*az-zayt*) became Spanish **aceite**, “oil.”
- الزَّيْتُونَة (*az-zaytūna*) became Spanish **aceituna**, “an olive.”

ز is a **sun letter**, which is why *al-* is said *az-* — the assimilation that makes *al-* + *sukkar* into *as-sukkar*. Spanish took the sound it heard, article and all. Portuguese did the same with **azeite**.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *zāy* is *rā* plus one dot above, and it breaks as *rā* breaks
- the dot families — *bāʾ*, *nūn*, *tāʾ*; *ḥāʾ*, *khāʾ*, *jīm*; *rā* and *zāy*
- *zāy*, *yāʾ*, *tāʾ* — “*zayt*,” oil
- the olives — *zaytūn*; one olive, *zaytūna*
- the welded article — *az-zayt* gave *aceite*, *as-sukkar* gave *azúcar*
- the friend and his root — *ṣadīq*, from *ṣ-d-q*, to be true
- the pair one letter apart — *ibn*, *bint*

Before you move on

What is *z*, described from a letter you had? (***Rā* with one dot above** — and it breaks the same way.) What does *ز-ي-ت* give besides oil? (***Zaytūn* and *zaytūna***.) Which Spanish words carry this root with Arabic’s article stuck on, and which one did *sukkar* give? (***Aceite* and *aceituna*; *azúcar***.) Why *az-* rather than *al-*? (*z* is a **sun letter**.)

36.2 كُوب (kūb) — “a cup,” and more than one of them

A short, useful word — and the door into the thing about Arabic nouns that surprises every learner.

The letters in this word

Nothing new. ك (kāf), the angular *k*; و (wāw), here carrying the long *ū*; and ب (bāʾ).

و is a non-joiner, so كُوب goes كُوب, break, ب. Another non-joiner: ر ended *sukkar*, ز opened *zayt*, and و splits this.

The word, taken apart — its root and its family

كُوب (kūb) = “a cup.” Root ب-و-ك.

Now say “cups.” In English you add an *s*. In Arabic you do something else entirely:

أَكْوَاب (akwāb).

Nothing was added to the end. The root ب-و-ك was taken out of one shape and **poured into another**, أَفْعَال (afʿāl). Arabic calls this a **broken plural**, and it is not an exception — it is how most ordinary Arabic nouns make their plurals.

You have seen a root move between shapes many times: ب-ت-ك became *kitāb*, *kātib*, *maktab*, *maktaba*. A broken plural is that same machinery pointed at number instead of meaning. So this is not a new rule to learn. It is a rule you already have, doing a job you did not expect it to do.

On where *kūb* came from, honesty first. It sits close to a cup-word that travelled all round the Mediterranean — Latin **cuppa**, behind English **cup** and French **coupe**. Whether Arabic took it from that family, or the resemblance is coincidence, is **not settled**: a resemblance worth knowing, not a descent worth claiming.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- kāf, wāw, bāʾ — “kūb,” a cup
- more than one — “akwāb,” and nothing was added to the end

- what happened instead — the root was poured into the shape af^cāl
- the same machinery you had — kitāb, kātib, maktab, maktaba
- ask for one — “kūb mā^ʔ, min faḍlik” — a cup of water, from your grace
- and answer the thanks — “^cafwan”
- the odd old word for water — mā^ʔ, whose plural miyāh follows no pattern
- the non-joiners — zāy in zayt, dāl in ṣaḍīq, wāw here

Before you move on

How does Arabic make “cups” out of كُوب? (*Akwāb* — the root is **re-poured into a new shape**, not given an ending. That is a **broken plural**.) Which earlier root shows the same shape-changing machinery? (كِتَاب — *kitāb, kātib, maktab, maktaba*.) Ask for a cup of water politely. (*Kūb mā^ʔ, min faḍlik*.) And reply to thanks? (*^cAfwan*.) Did Arabic get *kūb* from Latin *cuppa*? (**Unsettled** — a resemblance, not a claim.)

36.3 طبق (ṭabaq) — “a plate,” and a broken plural that repeats

One broken plural is a surprise. Two in the same shape is a pattern — and a pattern you can use.

The letters in this word

Nothing new. ط (ṭā^ʔ) is the emphatic ت, named when you built طعام (ṭa^cām) — the dark, flat-tongued *t*, standing beside ص under س and ض under د.

Then ب (bā^ʔ) and ق (qāf). All three join, so طبق runs unbroken — unlike كُوب, which had to stop at its wāw.

The word, taken apart — its root and its family

طَبَق (ṭabaq) = “a plate, a dish.” Root ط-ب-ق.
Its plural is أَطْبَاق (aṭbāq).

Say that beside أَكْوَاب (akwāb) and listen. Same opening أَ, same long ā before the last letter, same nothing-added-at-the-end. Both are the shape أَفْعَال (afʿāl). So the broken plural is not chaos: it is a small set of shapes, and you have now met the commonest one twice.

The root itself means **to cover, to lie in layers** — a plate being the flat thing that covers. Which is why the same root gives:

- طَابِق (ṭābiq) — “**a storey**” of a building. A layer of house. And notice its shape: that is the **doer** form of ṣādiq and kātib.
- طَبَقَة (ṭabaqa) — “**a layer**,” and so “**a social class**,” with the tied ʿ on the end.

A plate, a floor and a social class, off one idea about layers. And the plates themselves belong somewhere you already built: مَطْعَم (maṭʿam), the place of eating.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- ṭāʾ, bāʾ, qāf — “ṭabaq,” a plate
- the emphatic set once more — ṣād, ḍād, ṭāʾ
- the two broken plurals — akwāb, aṭbāq, both in the shape afʿāl
- what the root means — to cover, to lie in layers
- its other children — ṭābiq, a storey; ṭabaqa, a layer or a class
- where the plates live — maṭʿam, the place of eating
- the oil, whose zāy is rā plus a dot — zayt, zaytūn

Before you move on

What shape do أَكْوَاب and أَطْبَاق share? (**Afʿāl** — the broken plural you have now met twice.) What does ط-ب-ق mean? (**To cover, to lie in layers.**) Name two more words it builds. (**Ṭābiq**, a storey, and **ṭabaqa**, a layer or a class.) Which plain letter is ط the emphatic partner of? (**Tāʾ**.) Where would you find a stack of aṭbāq? (**In a**

maṭʿam — the place of eating.)

36.4 مَلْعَقَة (milʿaqa) — “a spoon,” the tool shape, and two ways to say more than one

The last word, and it pays two debts at once: the shape that makes tools, and the question of how Arabic counts past one.

The letters in this word

Nothing new: م (*mīm*), ل (*lām*), ع (*ʿayn*, the throat sound), ق (*qāf*) — and then ʾ, the tied *tāʾ*.

That ʾ tells you, before anything else, that مَلْعَقَة is **feminine** — the signal you read off قَهْوَة (*qahwa*), صَدِيقَة (*ṣadiqa*) and طَبَقَة (*ṭabaqa*).

The word, taken apart — its root and its family

مَلْعَقَة (*milʿaqa*) = “a spoon.” Root ل-ع-ق, whose verb لَعَقَ (*laʿiqa*) means “he licked, he lapped.” A spoon is the thing you lap with.

Two shapes now stand side by side, differing by one vowel:

- م, the **place** shape: مَكْتَب (maktab), the place of writing; مَطْعَم (*maṭʿam*), the place of eating.
- م, the **tool** shape: مِرْآة (*mirʾāh*), the thing you see with; مَلْعَقَة (*milʿaqa*), the thing you lap with.

Ma- builds a room. *Mi-* puts something in your hand.

Now the plurals this chapter has been circling.

Broken — the root re-poured, nothing added: أَكْوَاب (*akwāb*), أَطْبَاق (*aṭbāq*), مَلَاعِق (*malāʿiq*), spoons.

Sound — an ending added, the word left intact. Arabic uses it for the ʾ words: قَهْوَة gives قَهَوَات (*qahawāt*), and صَدِيقَة gives صَدِيقَات (*ṣadiqāt*).

The rule of thumb: a noun in ʾ usually takes the added ending, and most other everyday nouns break. *Milʿaqa* is the honest reminder that “usually” is doing work — it ends in ʾ and breaks anyway.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- mīm, lām, ʿayn, qāf, tāʾ marbūʿa — “mil^caqa,” a spoon
- the verb under it — “la^ciqa,” he lapped
- the place shape — maktab, maṭʿam
- the tool shape — mirʾāh, mil^caqa
- the broken plurals — kūb with its breaking wāw gives akwāb; aṭbāq; malāʿiq
- the sound plurals — qahwa gives qahawāt, ṣadīqa gives ṣadīqāt
- the tied tāʾ marking feminine — qahwa, ṣadīqa, ṭabaqa, mil^caqa
- ask for each — “kūb, min faḍlik”; “ṭabaq, min faḍlik”; “mil^caqa, min faḍlik”
- and the oil — zayt, whose Spanish child is aceite

Before you move on

What separates م from هـ? (**Ma-** makes a place, **mi-** a tool — *maktab* and *maṭʿam* against *mirʾāh* and *mil^caqa*.) What does ل-ع-ق mean? (**To lap**.) Name this chapter’s broken plurals, and a sound one. (*Akwāb*, *aṭbāq*, *malāʿiq*; *qahawāt* or *ṣadīqāt*.) What does the ʾ on *mil^caqa* tell you? (**Feminine** — and unusually for a ʾ word, it still breaks.) Ask for a spoon politely. (*Mil^caqa*, *min faḍlik*.)

Pronunciation & Script — a reference

Not to be read before the lessons — they teach reading through real words, each letter introduced as a word needs it. This page just gathers the system. Arabic appears both in script (مرحبا) and in transliteration (*marḥaban*), a dot marking the heavy/throaty consonants.

The script, in one breath

- **Right to left**, and letters **connect** — each has up to four shapes (isolated/initial/medial/final). Met inside real words, not drilled.
- Short vowels (*a i u*) are usually left unwritten; long vowels (*ā ī ū*) are letters (ا و ي).

Consonants with no English equivalent

- ح (ḥ): a heavy *h* from deep in the throat (vs. light ه).
- خ (kh): a throat-scrape = Scottish *loch*, **Spanish** *j*.
- ع (‘, “*ayn*”): a voiced throat-tightening; no English match.
- ء (‘, “hamza”): a glottal stop — the catch in “uh-oh.”
- ق (q): a *k* made far back; غ (gh): a gargled *g*.

Emphatic (“heavy”) consonants

ص ض ط ظ (ṣ, ḍ, ṭ, ṣ): heavier, deeper versions of *s*, *d*, *t*, *dh*. They change the word: ص س ≠ س *s*.

The article and sun/moon letters

ال (*al-*, “the”) attaches to its noun. Before a **sun letter** the *l* assimilates and the letter doubles: *al-salām* → *as-salām*. Before a **moon letter** it stays: *al-khayr*. The sun rule is fossilized in Spanish *azúcar* (from *as-sukkar*).

The root system

Most words are built on a **three-consonant root** carrying a core meaning, poured into vowel **patterns**: *k-t-b* (writing) → *kitāb* (book), *kātib* (writer), *maktab* (office). See the first lesson.